THE PERSON I COULDN'T FORGET

Romance • Friendship • College Life • Emotional Drama

Written by Vinay Deshmukh

THE INK HOUSE

THE PERSON I COULDN'T FORGET

A story of friendship, love, memories, and moving forward.

Written by Vinay Deshmukh
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The Ink House

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Some people enter our lives and stay forever. Others stay only long enough to change the way we understand friendship, love, and ourselves.

The Person I Couldn't Forget is a story about the spaces between those two kinds of people. It is about a friendship that feels permanent, a silence that changes everything, and the unexpected person who stays when life becomes difficult.

Aarav's journey is not about choosing one person over another. It is about learning that remembering someone does not mean you cannot move forward. Sometimes closure comes quietly, and sometimes happiness begins in the most ordinary moments.

I hope this story reminds you that the people we cannot forget can still have a place in our past, while the people beside us can become part of our future.

— Vinay Deshmukh

CONTENTS

Chapter 1 — The First Day 1
Chapter 2 — Best Friends 9
Chapter 3 — Everyone Knew 24
Chapter 4 — Just Us 41
Chapter 5 — The Three of Us 54
Chapter 6 — The Missed Calls 67
Chapter 7 — I Can Live Without You 82
Chapter 8 — Silence 94
Chapter 9 — The Accident 106
Chapter 10 — Too Late 116
Chapter 11 — Three Months Later 128
Chapter 12 — The Boy at the Beach 140
Chapter 13 — A New Number 153
Chapter 14 — Somehow, She Made Him Laugh 165
Chapter 15 — Things He Never Said 178
Chapter 16 — The Person Beside Him 190
Chapter 17 — The Longest Ride Back 204
Chapter 18 — Our Final Year 215
Chapter 19 — After the Last Day 226
Chapter 20 — The Person Who Came Back 237
Chapter 21 — I Don't Want to Lose You 249
Chapter 22 — Today 259
Chapter 23 — After Today 268
Chapter 24 — The Life We Built 280
Chapter 25 — Forever, Somehow 293

CHAPTER 1

The First Day

Mumbai had a strange way of making every beginning feel bigger than it really was.

For some people, the first day of college meant new clothes, new friends, new classrooms and a new freedom.

For Meera Kapoor, it meant something else.

It meant leaving behind everything she had known and starting a completely new chapter.

She stood outside the gates of **St. Aurelia College**, holding the strap of her bag tightly while students moved around her in every direction.

The campus was already alive.

People were laughing.

Some were taking photographs.

Some were desperately searching for their classrooms.

Others were standing in groups, already making friends as if they had known each other for years.

Meera smiled nervously.

“Okay,” she whispered to herself. “New college. New people. New life.”

She took a breath and stepped inside.

She had been waiting for this day for months.

But she had no idea that within the next few minutes, she would see someone she had spent years trying not to think about.

Aarav.

She hadn't spoken to him properly in years.

They had been in the same school, but they were never close.

Not really.

She had simply noticed him.

It started sometime during school.

Maybe it was the way he helped people without making a big deal about it.

Maybe it was the way he laughed with his friends.

Maybe it was the quiet confidence he had when he spoke.

Or maybe there was no particular reason at all.

She simply liked him.

And she had never told him.

Not once.

She had always assumed college would finally give her a chance to forget about him.

Then she heard a familiar voice.

“Bro, we're definitely going to get lost on the first day.”

Meera stopped.

Her heart suddenly beat faster.

She knew that voice.

Slowly, she turned around.

And there he was.

Aarav Malhotra.

Standing near the college courtyard with a backpack hanging from one shoulder.

Older than she remembered.

A little taller.

Same smile.

Same eyes.

Same Aarav.

Meera stared at him.

For a moment, she forgot where she was.

The noise of the college seemed to disappear.

Students were still walking around her, but she couldn't hear any of them.

All she could see was him.

He's here.

Her heart began beating faster.

She almost smiled.

Maybe this wasn't such a bad surprise after all.

She took one small step toward him.

Then another.

She was about to call his name.

“Aarav!”

A girl's voice came from behind him.

Aarav turned immediately.

His entire face changed.

He smiled.

“Kiara!”

Meera stopped.

A girl walked toward him.

She looked completely comfortable around him.

As if she belonged there.

As if she had been part of his life forever.

Kiara Sharma reached Aarav and smiled.

“You came without me?”

Aarav laughed.

“You're five minutes late.”

“Five minutes?”

“Okay, ten.”

She rolled her eyes.

Then, without thinking twice, she took his hand.

Naturally.

Comfortably.

Like it was the most normal thing in the world.

Meera's smile disappeared.

She stood there silently.

She didn't know who Kiara was.

But she didn't need an introduction.

The way Aarav looked at her told her enough.

Aarav and Kiara started walking toward the main building, still talking.

Meera watched them.

The excitement she had felt only a few seconds ago slowly disappeared.

She looked down.

Then she quietly turned around.

She walked away before either of them could notice her.

She didn't want Aarav to see her.

She didn't want Kiara to see her.

Most of all, she didn't want anyone to see the disappointment on her face.

She reached the other side of the courtyard and stopped.

For a second, she looked back.

Aarav was still walking beside Kiara.

Laughing.

Talking.

Happy.

Meera took a deep breath.

“Of course,” she whispered.

“Of course he's with her.”

She adjusted her bag and walked toward her classroom.

She didn't know it yet, but the girl holding Aarav's hand wasn't just some girl.

She was his best friend.

His oldest friend.

The person who had known him long before college.

The person who had been beside him through almost everything.

And Meera had just seen the beginning of a story she didn't know would eventually change all three of their lives.

A few minutes later, Aarav and Kiara entered their classroom.

“First bench?” Kiara asked.

“Absolutely not.”

“Why?”

“Because I don't want the professor to know my name on the first day.”

Kiara laughed.

“You're impossible.”

They took seats somewhere in the middle.

Aarav looked around the classroom.

“So this is it.”

Kiara nodded.

“Three years.”

“Three years.”

Neither of them knew how much those three years would change them.

Outside the classroom, Meera walked down the corridor alone.

She didn't know Aarav was in the same class.

She didn't know Kiara's name.

She didn't know why they were so close.

She only knew one thing.

The boy she had quietly liked since school was sitting somewhere inside that classroom.

And the girl beside him already had a place in his life.

A place Meera had never been brave enough to ask for.

She opened the classroom door.

And stepped inside.

For the first time.

CHAPTER 2

Best Friends

Some friendships don't begin with a dramatic moment.

There is no first confession, no big promise, no perfect photograph that marks the beginning.

Sometimes, two people simply keep choosing each other.

Again and again.

Until one day, everyone around them realizes they have become inseparable.

That was Aarav and Kiara.

Their story had started long before St. Aurelia College.

It had started in Class 9.

The first time Aarav noticed Kiara, she was sitting at the last bench.

She had forgotten her mathematics notebook.

Again.

“Can I see yours?” she whispered.

Aarav looked at her.

“You didn't bring it?”

Kiara shook her head innocently.

“You said that yesterday too.”

“And I'll probably say it tomorrow.”

Aarav sighed and moved his notebook between them.

“Fine. But don't fold the pages this time.”

Kiara smiled.

“No promises.”

That was it.

Nothing special.

At least, not then.

But somehow, that small moment became the beginning of something neither of them expected.

Within a few weeks, they were sitting together during lunch.

Within a few months, they were sharing notes, complaining about teachers, arguing over which movie to watch, and walking home together after school.

By the end of Class 9, everyone knew them as a pair.

Not a couple.

Best friends.

And they corrected anyone who suggested otherwise.

“Are you two dating?” someone once asked.

Kiara immediately pointed at Aarav.

“Absolutely not.”

Aarav nodded seriously.

“She is too annoying.”

Kiara stared at him.

“You're the one who calls me every evening.”

“Because you never finish your homework.”

“You literally send me your homework.”

“So you can learn.”

“You send answers.”

“Same thing.”

She laughed.

And somehow, that became their normal.

Years passed.

Class 10.

Then Class 11.

Then Class 12.

Their friendship survived exams, arguments, school trips, bad marks, good marks, family functions, birthdays and hundreds of completely unnecessary conversations.

They had their own language.

One look could mean *Let's leave.*

One raised eyebrow could mean *Don't say anything.*

A smile could mean *I'm fine.*

And sometimes, silence meant everything.

Aarav knew when Kiara was upset even when she said she wasn't.

Kiara knew when Aarav was pretending to be okay.

They knew each other's favorite food.

They knew which songs the other secretly liked.

They knew each other's biggest fears.

They even knew what college they wanted to attend.

And when they both got into St. Aurelia College in Mumbai, neither of them was surprised.

On the day their admission was confirmed, Kiara called Aarav immediately.

“You got in!”

“So did you.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you screaming?”

“Because we're going together!”

Aarav laughed.

“It's college, Kiara. Not a vacation.”

“For me, it's both.”

“You're going to study.”

“Obviously.”

“How much?”

There was silence.

“Kiara?”

“Let's not ruin the first day.”

Aarav laughed again.

“You're impossible.”

“And you're stuck with me.”

He smiled at the phone.

“Yeah.”

Neither of them knew how important that sentence would become.

Back at St. Aurelia, on the first day of college, they walked through the campus like they had done this a hundred times.

Except they hadn't.

Everything was new.

New classrooms.

New teachers.

New faces.

New friends.

New memories waiting to happen.

But Aarav had one familiar person beside him.

Kiara.

She was walking next to him, talking about everything at once.

“I'm telling you, the canteen better be good.”

“You haven't even seen it.”

“I can already judge it.”

“Based on what?”

“Vibes.”

Aarav shook his head.

“You're going to survive college entirely on vibes, aren't you?”

“Maybe.”

They reached the classroom.

Kiara looked inside.

“Second bench.”

Aarav frowned.

“Why?”

“Because the first bench is too serious.”

“You're the one who wanted good marks.”

“I want good marks without looking like I want good marks.”

“That makes absolutely no sense.”

“It makes perfect sense.”

She walked inside.

Aarav followed.

They sat together.

As usual.

A few students around them began talking.

“Are you guys friends from school?”

Kiara answered before Aarav could.

“Best friends.”

Aarav nodded.

“Since Class 9.”

“Wow,” someone said. “So you came to the same college together?”

“Yep,” Kiara replied.

“Lucky.”

Aarav looked at Kiara.

She smiled.

“Very.”

Over the next few weeks, their friendship became obvious to everyone.

If Aarav went to the canteen, Kiara went with him.

If Kiara needed to shop for something, Aarav was dragged along.

If Aarav had to watch a movie, Kiara had already decided which one.

If Kiara wanted to go somewhere after college, Aarav was usually the first person she called.

They travelled around Mumbai together.

Marine Drive.

Cafés.

Bookstores.

Shopping streets.

Small food places.

Random roads they had no reason to take.

Sometimes they would simply sit somewhere and talk for hours.

They didn't need a plan.

They just needed time.

One rainy evening, they were returning from college on Aarav's bike.

Mumbai was covered in grey clouds.

Rain had started falling lightly.

Kiara sat behind him, holding the side handle.

“Slow down!”

“I'm already slow!”

“You call this slow?”

“You're the one who wanted to leave before the rain got worse.”

“I changed my mind.”

“Of course you did.”

She laughed.

At a red light, Aarav looked at her through the mirror.

“You okay?”

“Yeah.”

“Sure?”

“Yeah.”

He nodded.

The signal turned green.

They continued.

A few minutes later, Kiara suddenly said,

“Aarav?”

“Hm?”

“Do you think we'll still be friends after college?”

He laughed.

“What kind of question is that?”

“A normal one.”

“We've been friends for years.”

“So?”

“So nothing is going to change.”

Kiara was quiet.

Aarav continued,

“Three years of college. Then jobs. Then whatever comes next.”

“And?”

“And I'll still annoy you.”

She smiled.

“And I'll still annoy you.”

“Exactly.”

She looked at the road ahead.

“Promise?”

Aarav didn't hesitate.

“Promise.”

Neither of them noticed someone standing across the road at a small café.

Meera.

She had just stepped outside with a friend.

She saw them.

Aarav on the bike.

Kiara behind him.

Both laughing.

Meera stopped walking.

She watched them disappear into the traffic.

Her friend looked at her.

“Who was that?”

Meera forced a small smile.

“Someone I know from school.”

“Boyfriend?”

Meera immediately shook her head.

“No.”

“Then?”

Meera looked at the road again.

“I don't know.”

But she did know.

At least, she thought she did.

She had liked Aarav for years.

Quietly.

Without telling him.

She had always believed that one day she would find the right moment to say something.

But every time she saw Aarav with Kiara, that moment seemed to move further away.

Because some friendships were so close that outsiders didn't know where they could possibly fit.

And Meera didn't want to destroy something beautiful just because of what she felt.

So she stayed quiet.

Back at the college hostel area, Aarav and Kiara stopped near a small tea stall.

Kiara removed her helmet.

“You know what?”

“What?”

“We should make a list.”

“A list of what?”

“Things we have to do before graduation.”

Aarav smiled.

“Okay.”

She counted on her fingers.

“Trip.”

“Definitely.”

“Beach at midnight.”

“That's two.”

“Movie marathon.”

“Three.”

“Go somewhere outside Mumbai.”

“Four.”

“Take a ridiculous number of pictures.”

“You already do that.”

“Then we're halfway done.”

Aarav laughed.

Kiara looked at him.

“And one more.”

“What?”

“No matter what happens, we don't stop talking.”

Aarav's smile faded slightly.

“Why are you suddenly making everything serious?”

“Because college changes people.”

“Not us.”

“You don't know that.”

Aarav looked at her for a moment.

Then he smiled.

“Fine.”

He held out his hand.

“Deal.”

Kiara looked at his hand and laughed.

“We're not five.”

“Then don't shake it.”

She rolled her eyes and shook his hand anyway.

“Deal.”

They both laughed.

Neither of them knew that, one day, that promise would be the first thing they would break.

And neither knew how much it would hurt when they did.

For now, though, they were still just Aarav and Kiara.

Best friends.

Two people who believed their friendship could survive anything.

And somewhere between them, without either of them noticing,

Meera was waiting for a place in Aarav's life.

Not knowing that the hardest part wouldn't be getting close to him.

It would be learning how to stay when the person he couldn't forget was someone else.

CHAPTER 3

Everyone Knew

By the end of the first month at St. Aurelia College, everyone had figured it out.

Aarav and Kiara were always together.

Not because they had planned it.

Not because they were trying to prove anything.

It just happened.

If Aarav was sitting in the canteen, Kiara was probably sitting across from him.

If Kiara was walking through the corridor, Aarav was usually beside her.

If someone needed Aarav, they often called Kiara first.

And if someone couldn't find Kiara, they already knew where to look.

With Aarav.

It became a running joke among their new friends.

“Are you two actually capable of spending one hour apart?”

Aarav looked up from his phone.

“Yes.”

Kiara immediately said, “No.”

Everyone laughed.

Aarav turned toward her.

“Why did you say no?”

“Because you can't survive without me.”

“I literally survived before I met you.”

“Barely.”

“That's not true.”

Kiara smiled.

“Prove it.”

Aarav opened his mouth, then stopped.

Their friends laughed even harder.

“See?” Kiara said proudly. “No answer.”

Aarav shook his head.

“You're impossible.”

“And yet you're still here.”

“Unfortunately.”

She smiled.

“Exactly.”

Across the table, Meera watched them quietly.

She smiled too.

But there was something she never said.

She understood why everyone thought they were a couple.

Sometimes, even she couldn't tell where friendship ended and something deeper might have begun.

Meera had slowly become part of their group.

At first, she stayed mostly quiet.

She attended lectures, took notes, smiled at everyone's jokes and went home.

But Aarav made it easy for her to talk.

He never forced conversations.

He simply included people.

One afternoon, the group was sitting outside their classroom waiting for the professor.

Aarav looked around.

“Has anyone completed the assignment?”

Everyone became suspiciously silent.

Aarav laughed.

“Okay. So nobody.”

Meera raised her hand slightly.

“I did.”

Aarav looked at her.

“You did?”

She nodded.

“Yeah.”

“Can I see it?”

“Why?”

“So I can understand the format.”

Kiara immediately laughed.

“You mean copy it.”

Aarav looked offended.

“I would never.”

Meera smiled.

“You can see it.”

“Thank you.”

Kiara leaned toward Meera.

“Don't trust him.”

Aarav looked at Kiara.

“Why are you destroying my reputation?”

“What reputation?”

Everyone laughed.

Meera laughed too.

And for the first time, she felt completely comfortable around them.

She wasn't just the girl from school anymore.

She was becoming part of the group.

Part of their college life.

Part of Aarav's everyday world.

But even then, there was always Kiara.

One Friday afternoon, the group decided to go shopping after college.

There were six of them.

Aarav.

Kiara.

Meera.

And three other friends from their class.

They walked through the crowded streets, arguing over where to eat.

“Pizza.”

“Chinese.”

“South Indian.”

“Anything except pizza.”

Aarav looked at Kiara.

“You're the only person who understands me.”

Kiara smiled.

“Obviously.”

Meera walked beside them.

She watched the way they talked.

They didn't need to explain themselves.

They understood each other's expressions.

When Aarav picked up a shirt and made a doubtful face, Kiara immediately said,

“Don't buy that.”

He put it back.

“How did you know I didn't like it?”

“You made your face.”

“What face?”

“That face.”

He laughed.

“You're weird.”

“You're predictable.”

Meera smiled.

“You two really know each other.”

Kiara looked at her.

“Too well.”

Aarav nodded.

“Unfortunately.”

Kiara lightly pushed his shoulder.

“Shut up.”

Everyone laughed.

But Meera noticed something else.

Kiara never seemed uncomfortable around Aarav.

She trusted him completely.

And Aarav trusted her just as much.

There was no hesitation.

No awkwardness.

No uncertainty.

Just years of knowing each other.

Meera wondered what it would feel like to have someone know her that well.

Then she looked at Aarav.

And immediately knew who she wished that person could be.

That evening, the group stopped at a small café.

They pushed two tables together and sat around them.

Someone started talking about relationships.

It was the kind of conversation that happened whenever a group of college students had too much free time.

“Okay,” one of their friends said. “Who here has a crush?”

Everyone started laughing.

“Why are you asking?”

“Because there has to be someone.”

Aarav took a sip of his drink.

“Not me.”

Kiara looked at him.

“Definitely not me.”

Their friend pointed at them.

“You two are suspicious.”

“Why?”

“Because whenever someone asks about relationships, you both answer at the same time.”

Aarav laughed.

“We're best friends.”

“That's what everyone says.”

Kiara rolled her eyes.

“Believe whatever you want.”

Then someone looked at Meera.

“What about you?”

Meera froze for half a second.

“Me?”

“Yes, you.”

She smiled awkwardly.

“No one.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Really?”

She nodded.

“Really.”

It wasn't exactly a lie.

She hadn't told anyone.

And technically, she had no relationship with Aarav.

So she could say no.

But the truth was sitting right across the table.

Smiling at her.

Completely unaware.

Later that night, Meera opened her phone.

There was a new message from Aarav.

Aarav: *Did you reach home?*

Meera stared at it.

She smiled.

Meera: *Yeah. You?*

A few seconds later:

Aarav: *Just reached.*

Then:

Aarav: *You were quiet today.*

Meera thought for a moment.

Meera: *I was just tired.*

Aarav: *Okay.*

Then another message appeared.

Aarav: *Goodnight, Meera.*

She looked at those two words for longer than she should have.

Goodnight.

Nothing special.

Just two simple words.

But for Meera, they meant something.

She typed:

Meera: *Goodnight, Aarav.*

She placed the phone beside her pillow.

Then picked it up again.

She opened their conversation.

Read it once.

Then again.

And smiled.

Maybe she didn't need to tell him yet.

Maybe being his friend was enough.

For now.

The next morning, Aarav and Kiara were already waiting outside college when Meera arrived.

Kiara waved.

“Meera!”

Meera walked toward them.

“Hi.”

Aarav held out a coffee.

“I got an extra.”

She looked surprised.

“For me?”

“Yeah.”

Kiara immediately looked at Aarav.

“You never get me coffee.”

“You don't like this one.”

“That has never stopped you before.”

Aarav laughed.

Meera took the cup.

“Thanks.”

“No problem.”

Kiara looked at Meera and smiled.

“See? He's useful sometimes.”

Aarav shook his head.

“Only sometimes?”

“Don't push it.”

The three of them walked toward the college building together.

For the first time, it didn't feel like Aarav and Kiara with Meera following behind.

It felt like three friends walking together.

And that small difference meant more to Meera than anyone knew.

Over the next few weeks, things became even easier.

They studied together.

They ate together.

They shared notes.

They went out after lectures.

They made plans for weekends.

And slowly, Meera became someone Aarav looked for when he entered the classroom.

Sometimes he saved her a seat.

Sometimes he sent her a meme during a boring lecture.

Sometimes they talked late at night about completely meaningless things.

She began to know his habits.

He hated overly sweet coffee.

He always forgot where he kept his keys.

He listened to the same songs repeatedly.

He became quiet when something bothered him.

And whenever he was nervous, he tapped his fingers against the table.

Meera noticed everything.

She never told him.

Kiara noticed too.

One afternoon, after Aarav had left to submit some paperwork, Kiara looked at Meera.

“You really like him, don't you?”

Meera's smile disappeared.

“What?”

Kiara smiled softly.

“Relax. I'm not angry.”

“I don't—”

“You don't have to explain.”

Meera looked down.

For a few seconds, neither spoke.

Then Kiara said,

“He's lucky to have people who care about him.”

Meera looked at her.

“You really love him, don't you?”

Kiara smiled.

“Of course.”

Meera's heart sank slightly.

But Kiara continued.

“Not like that.”

Meera looked up.

“Then how?”

Kiara thought for a moment.

“Like family.”

That answer stayed with Meera.

Family.

Maybe that was what Aarav and Kiara were.

Maybe their friendship wasn't something Meera needed to compete with.

Maybe she could simply be another person who cared about him.

So she smiled.

“Then I guess we're both stuck with him.”

Kiara laughed.

“Unfortunately.”

And just like that, the tension disappeared.

That evening, the three of them sat on the college steps after everyone else had left.

The sky was turning orange.

Mumbai was beginning to light up.

Aarav leaned back on the steps.

“We should go somewhere this weekend.”

“Where?” Meera asked.

“Anywhere.”

Kiara immediately said, “Nature.”

Aarav smiled.

“Of course.”

Meera laughed.

“You two already have an answer.”

Kiara looked at her.

“You're coming.”

Meera smiled.

“Okay.”

Aarav looked at both of them.

“Then it's decided.”

They sat there for a while.

Three friends.

One friendship.

One secret.

And one bond that seemed impossible to break.

At least, that's what they believed.

Because sometimes the happiest moments are the ones you don't realize you'll miss later.

And sometimes, the people sitting beside you today become the memories you spend years trying to understand.

For now, though, none of them knew what was coming.

They only knew that college had just begun.

And they had three years ahead of them.

Three years that would change everything.

CHAPTER 4

Just Us

Some evenings don't need a plan.

You don't decide where you're going.

You don't decide how long you'll stay.

You just get on a bike, leave the noise of the city behind, and let the road decide.

That was exactly what Aarav and Kiara did one Friday evening.

College had ended early.

Their friends had already made plans for the weekend, but Aarav and Kiara wanted something quieter.

“Where are we going?” Kiara asked as she put on her helmet.

“Don't know.”

She stared at him.

“You invited me somewhere without knowing where we're going?”

“Yep.”

“Very responsible.”

“Thank you.”

“That wasn't a compliment.”

“I'll take it anyway.”

She laughed and climbed onto the bike.

“Okay. Let's go.”

Aarav started the engine.

They left the college gates and entered the busy Mumbai roads.

The evening traffic was heavy, but neither of them was in a hurry.

For once, they had nowhere to be.

After nearly an hour, they reached a quieter road near the outskirts of the city.

The traffic slowly disappeared.

Buildings became fewer.

Trees replaced concrete.

Kiara looked around.

“This is actually nice.”

“I told you.”

“You didn't tell me anything.”

“Exactly.”

She laughed.

They eventually stopped near a small hill overlooking the city.

The sky was turning orange.

Mumbai stretched out in the distance, glowing under the evening light.

Kiara removed her helmet and walked toward the edge.

Aarav parked the bike and followed.

For a few moments, neither said anything.

They simply stood there.

Together.

Kiara looked at the skyline.

“Do you ever think about what we'll be doing five years from now?”

Aarav smiled.

“You've asked me this before.”

“And?”

“I still don't know.”

“You have to have some idea.”

“Maybe I'll have a good job.”

“That's boring.”

“Okay. I'll be rich.”

“That's better.”

“And I'll buy a huge house.”

“With what money?”

“Future money.”

Kiara laughed.

“Very realistic.”

“What about you?”

She thought for a moment.

“I want to travel.”

“Where?”

“Everywhere.”

“That isn't a place.”

“I know.”

She smiled.

“I just don't want my life to become the same thing every day.”

Aarav nodded.

“I understand.”

“What about us?”

Aarav looked at her.

“What about us?”

“When we're older.”

He smiled.

“We'll still be friends.”

Kiara looked at him.

“You say that like it's guaranteed.”

“It is.”

“You're very confident.”

“I know you too well.”

She smiled.

“And what if one of us gets married?”

Aarav laughed.

“Then the other person will complain about the wedding.”

“Obviously.”

“And then we'll still talk.”

“Every day?”

“Maybe not every day.”

“Then?”

“Every other day.”

Kiara pretended to think.

“Fine.”

Aarav smiled.

“Deal.”

They sat on a bench for a while.

Kiara opened her phone.

“Look.”

She showed him a photograph of the three of them from college.

Aarav, Kiara and Meera.

They were all smiling.

“That's actually a good photo,” Aarav said.

“Obviously. I'm in it.”

“You ruined it.”

Kiara hit his arm.

“Shut up.”

Aarav laughed.

She looked at the photograph again.

“Meera's nice.”

“Yeah.”

“You like her?”

Aarav looked confused.

“As a friend?”

Kiara rolled her eyes.

“Obviously.”

“Yeah. She's really nice.”

Kiara smiled.

“She seems happy around us.”

“She is.”

“And you?”

“What about me?”

“Are you happy?”

Aarav looked at the city.

Then at her.

“Yeah.”

Kiara smiled.

“Good.”

She put her phone away.

Neither of them knew that Meera had become important to their story.

But neither knew exactly how important.

The sun slowly disappeared.

A cool breeze moved through the trees.

Kiara stood up.

“We should go.”

“Why?”

“Because my mother is going to call.”

Aarav laughed.

“Your mother knows you're with me?”

“Yes.”

“What did you tell her?”

“That I'm with my best friend.”

Aarav smiled.

“Good answer.”

She looked at him.

“Because it's true.”

They walked back toward the bike.

On the way, Kiara suddenly stopped.

“Aarav.”

“Hm?”

“Promise me something.”

He looked at her.

“What?”

“No matter what happens between us…”

She paused.

“…don't let one bad day destroy everything.”

Aarav frowned.

“Why would one bad day do that?”

“I don't know.”

“Then why are you saying it?”

“Just promise.”

He looked at her for a moment.

Then nodded.

“Okay.”

She held out her hand.

“Promise?”

He shook it.

“Promise.”

Kiara smiled.

“Good.”

The ride back was quieter.

The city lights slowly appeared around them.

Aarav drove carefully.

Kiara sat behind him, watching the roads pass by.

She didn't know why she'd asked him for that promise.

Maybe it was just a thought.

Maybe it was fear.

Maybe some part of her knew that friendships could change even when you didn't want them to.

But she pushed the thought away.

Tonight was good.

Tonight was theirs.

Just Aarav and Kiara.

Just two best friends riding through Mumbai.

No arguments.

No expectations.

No future problems.

Just them.

When they reached home, Aarav received a message.

Meera: *Reached?*

He smiled.

Aarav: *Yeah. You?*

Meera: *Home.*

A second later:

Meera: *Did you and Kiara go somewhere?*

Aarav replied:

Aarav: *Yeah. Just drove around.*

Meera: *Sounds nice.*

Aarav: *It was.*

He put his phone down.

A few seconds later, he picked it up again.

Aarav: *Next time you're coming too.*

Meera stared at the message.

She smiled.

Meera: *Promise?*

Aarav replied:

Aarav: *Promise.*

Meera put her phone beside her.

For the first time, she felt like she wasn't standing outside their friendship anymore.

Maybe there was room for her.

Maybe she could become part of their little world.

She didn't know that one day, that same world would change completely.

The next morning, Aarav and Kiara met outside college as usual.

“Coffee?” Kiara asked.

“Already bought.”

“For me?”

“No.”

She stared at him.

Aarav laughed and handed her one.

“Obviously.”

Kiara smiled.

“You're learning.”

“From the best.”

“Exactly.”

They walked inside together.

Meera was waiting near the classroom.

When she saw them, she smiled.

“Good morning.”

“Morning,” Aarav said.

Kiara smiled too.

The three of them entered the classroom together.

It was an ordinary morning.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing unusual.

Just another day at college.

But sometimes, ordinary days become the ones you remember most.

Because you never know when life is quietly moving toward a moment that will change everything.

For Aarav, Kiara and Meera, that moment was still somewhere ahead.

And for now, they were happy.

Together.

Just us.

All three of them.

CHAPTER 5

The Three of Us

By the middle of their first year, something had changed.

Not between Aarav and Kiara.

They were still the same.

Still arguing over the smallest things.

Still walking into college together.

Still sharing food.

Still making plans without telling anyone.

But now there was someone else.

Meera.

Somewhere along the way, she had stopped being the girl who happened to know Aarav from school.

She had become their friend.

Their real friend.

And slowly, the three of them became a familiar sight around St. Aurelia College.

Aarav.

Kiara.

Meera.

The three of them.

It started with small things.

One afternoon, Meera forgot her lunch.

Kiara noticed.

“You didn't bring anything?”

Meera shook her head.

“I was getting late.”

Kiara immediately opened her lunchbox.

“Take half.”

Meera smiled.

“No, it's okay.”

“I'm not asking.”

Aarav looked at Kiara.

“You're sharing your food?”

“Why are you surprised?”

“You never share.”

Kiara looked offended.

“I share with people I like.”

Aarav smiled.

“So I don't count?”

“You especially don't count.”

Meera laughed.

Aarav looked at her.

“See what I deal with every day?”

Meera smiled.

“Honestly, I think you're both equally annoying.”

Kiara looked at her.

“Finally. Someone understands.”

Aarav shook his head.

“I regret introducing you two.”

“You didn't introduce us,” Kiara said.

“We just became friends.”

Meera smiled.

And that was exactly how it happened.

No announcement.

No special moment.

Just friendship growing naturally.

Their group started making plans almost every weekend.

Sometimes they went to cafés.

Sometimes they went shopping.

Sometimes they simply sat at Marine Drive and talked until someone realized it was getting late.

One Sunday afternoon, they decided to go to a small nature spot outside the city.

Aarav brought his bike.

Kiara sat behind him.

Meera came with another friend.

The whole day was full of laughter.

They took hundreds of photographs.

Most of them were terrible.

Some were blurry.

Some had someone looking away.

Some were taken at the exact wrong moment.

But everyone kept them anyway.

At one point, Aarav tried taking a group selfie.

“Everyone come closer.”

Kiara moved beside him.

Meera stood on the other side.

“Wait,” Meera said. “My hair.”

Aarav laughed.

“It's fine.”

“No, it isn't.”

Kiara adjusted Meera's hair.

“There. Perfect.”

Aarav raised the phone.

“Ready?”

“Wait!”

“What now?”

“I blinked.”

“You haven't even taken it yet.”

“Still.”

Everyone laughed.

Aarav finally took the photograph.

Three smiles.

One frame.

A memory none of them thought twice about.

Later that evening, they sat near a small lake.

The others were talking a little distance away.

Aarav, Kiara and Meera sat together.

Kiara threw a small stone into the water.

“I'm going to miss this.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Miss what?”

“This.”

She looked around.

“College. All of us together. Everything.”

“We're not graduating tomorrow.”

“I know.”

“Then stop being dramatic.”

Kiara smiled.

“I'm allowed.”

Meera looked at them.

“You both really think too far ahead.”

Aarav nodded.

“That's Kiara.”

Kiara looked at him.

“And you're not?”

“No.”

Meera laughed.

“You definitely are.”

Aarav looked at her.

“How?”

“You're always planning things.”

“That's because someone has to.”

Kiara pointed at him.

“Exactly. That's why he's useful.”

Aarav smiled.

“Thank you.”

“You're welcome.”

For a moment, none of them spoke.

The wind moved across the water.

The sky was turning orange.

Meera looked at Aarav.

He was smiling.

Not because of anything special.

Just because he was happy.

And she quietly realized something.

She didn't only like him anymore.

She cared about his happiness.

Even if it didn't include her.

A few days later, Meera and Kiara were alone in the college library.

Aarav had gone to submit an assignment.

Kiara closed her book.

“Can I ask you something?”

Meera looked up.

“Sure.”

“You still like him?”

Meera became quiet.

She knew exactly who Kiara meant.

“Yes.”

Kiara smiled slightly.

“I thought so.”

“Is it obvious?”

“To me.”

Meera looked down at the book.

“I've liked him since school.”

“Does he know?”

“No.”

“Why haven't you told him?”

Meera took a breath.

“Because I don't want things to become awkward.”

Kiara nodded.

“That makes sense.”

Meera looked at her.

“Do you think I should tell him?”

Kiara didn't answer immediately.

Instead, she asked,

“What do you want?”

“I don't know.”

“Then don't rush.”

Meera smiled faintly.

“You're surprisingly good at this.”

“I'm good at many things.”

“Except studying.”

Kiara laughed.

“Exactly.”

Meera smiled.

Then Kiara became serious again.

“Whatever happens, don't feel like you have to compete with me.”

Meera looked surprised.

“I don't.”

“You might.”

“Why?”

“Because Aarav and I have been best friends for years.”

“I know.”

“But that doesn't mean there isn't space for other people.”

Meera looked at her quietly.

Kiara continued.

“If he becomes your friend, let him.”

“And if he becomes more?”

Kiara smiled.

“Then that's life.”

Meera didn't know what to say.

Kiara simply opened her book again.

The conversation was over.

But Meera carried those words with her.

There is space for other people.

For the first time, she allowed herself to believe that maybe she had a chance.

That evening, the three of them met at the college gate.

Aarav was holding three cups of coffee.

“One for each.”

Kiara took hers.

Meera smiled.

“Thank you.”

Aarav looked at them.

“Why are you both looking at me like that?”

Kiara smiled.

“Nothing.”

Meera laughed.

“Nothing.”

Aarav narrowed his eyes.

“You're hiding something.”

“We're not.”

“You definitely are.”

Kiara started walking.

“Come on.”

Aarav followed.

Meera walked beside him.

For a moment, the three of them were quiet.

Then Aarav said,

“You know what?”

“What?” Meera asked.

“I think this is going to be a really good year.”

Kiara smiled.

“It already is.”

Meera looked at both of them.

“Yeah.”

Aarav looked ahead.

“Imagine us three years from now.”

Kiara laughed.

“Hopefully more mature.”

Meera smiled.

“Hopefully.”

Aarav nodded.

“We'll still be together.”

Kiara looked at him.

“You're sure?”

“Of course.”

She smiled.

“Good.”

They continued walking.

Three friends.

Three different hearts.

Three different feelings.

Aarav thought he had everything he needed.

Kiara believed their friendship was strong enough to survive anything.

And Meera quietly hoped that one day, Aarav might look at her the way she had always looked at him.

None of them knew that the happiest part of their first year was slowly becoming a memory.

Because sometimes, life doesn't warn you before changing.

It simply does.

And their next year was going to begin with a silence none of them expected.

CHAPTER 6

The Missed Calls

The second year of college began quietly.

No warning.

No dramatic sign.

Just another morning in Mumbai.

Another crowded road.

Another lecture.

Another cup of coffee.

Another message from Kiara asking Aarav where he was.

At least, that's how it was supposed to be.

Aarav and Kiara had completed their first year exactly the way they had imagined.

They had made memories.

They had travelled.

They had laughed.

They had fought over stupid things and made up before the day ended.

And Meera had become an important part of their lives.

Everything felt normal.

Almost too normal.

On the first day of second year, Aarav reached college early.

He stood near the entrance with his phone in his hand.

He checked the time.

8:42 a.m.

Kiara was late.

He called her.

No answer.

He waited five minutes.

Called again.

Still nothing.

Aarav smiled to himself.

“Typical Kiara.”

He sent a message.

Aarav: *Where are you?*

No reply.

He put his phone away and entered the college.

Meera was already there.

“Good morning.”

“Morning.”

“Where's Kiara?”

“Late.”

Meera smiled.

“She'll come.”

“I know.”

They walked toward the classroom.

Aarav kept looking at the door.

Five minutes passed.

Then ten.

Then fifteen.

Still nothing.

He called again.

The phone was switched off.

His smile disappeared.

“That's strange.”

Meera looked at him.

“What?”

“Her phone is switched off.”

“Maybe her battery died.”

“Maybe.”

He tried not to think about it.

By lunchtime, Kiara still hadn't arrived.

Aarav had called her several times.

No answer.

His messages remained unread.

He asked one of their friends if they had heard from her.

“No.”

“Did she tell you anything?”

“No. Why?”

Aarav shook his head.

“Nothing.”

But something didn't feel right.

Kiara never disappeared without telling him.

Not for an entire morning.

Not without a message.

Not without answering his calls.

She had always been the person he could reach.

No matter what.

At around four in the afternoon, Aarav finally received a message.

Not from Kiara.

From one of their classmates.

She came to college earlier. I think I saw her near the parking area.

Aarav stared at the message.

Earlier?

Then why hadn't she come to class?

He called her again.

Still switched off.

He tried once more.

Nothing.

That evening, he sat outside the college gate with Meera.

“You're worried,” Meera said.

Aarav looked at his phone.

“She's never done this before.”

“Maybe something happened at home.”

“She would've told me.”

“Maybe she couldn't.”

Aarav didn't answer.

Meera could see that he was genuinely worried.

She gently said,

“She'll be okay.”

Aarav nodded.

“I hope so.”

The next morning, Kiara finally appeared.

Aarav saw her walking through the college gate.

Relief came first.

Then anger.

He immediately walked toward her.

“Where were you?”

Kiara stopped.

“What?”

“I called you all day.”

She looked away.

“I know.”

“You know?”

“My phone was off.”

“Why?”

“I had some things going on.”

“What things?”

“Aarav—”

“No. Seriously. What happened?”

Kiara sighed.

“Nothing.”

“Then why didn't you tell me?”

“I didn't think I had to explain everything.”

Aarav stared at her.

“What?”

“I said I was busy.”

“You were gone the entire day.”

“I know.”

“I called you so many times.”

“I know.”

“And you couldn't send one message?”

Kiara became quiet.

“Aarav, I didn't feel like talking.”

He looked at her in disbelief.

“Didn't feel like talking?”

“Yes.”

“Not even to me?”

She didn't answer.

That silence hurt more than he expected.

A few of their friends came over.

They could sense the tension immediately.

One of them tried to lighten the mood.

“Bro, relax. You act like you can't survive one day without Kiara.”

Someone else laughed.

“Seriously. Aarav without Kiara is impossible.”

Another friend joined in.

“Forget one day. He can't even survive one lecture.”

Everyone laughed.

Everyone except Aarav.

He was already frustrated.

Worried.

Embarrassed.

And now everyone was making jokes about it.

Kiara looked at him.

“Aarav…”

But he was already angry.

“I can live without her.”

The laughter stopped.

Kiara's expression changed.

Aarav continued.

“I don't need someone to be with me every second.”

Kiara stared at him.

“I never said you did.”

“Then stop acting like I can't do anything without you.”

“I don't act like that.”

“You do.”

“No, I don't.”

“Yes, you do!”

Their friends became completely silent.

Meera stood a few steps away.

She had never seen them like this.

Not really.

Aarav took a breath.

“I'm tired of everyone treating us like we're some kind of package deal.”

Kiara looked hurt.

“Everyone?”

“You know what I mean.”

“No, Aarav. I don't.”

He looked away.

She stepped closer.

“If you're angry because I didn't answer your calls, just say that.”

“I already did.”

“No. You're saying everything except that.”

Aarav clenched his jaw.

“You know what?”

“What?”

“Leave me alone, Kiara. Please.”

She froze.

Those words seemed to silence everything around them.

For a few seconds, neither moved.

Then Kiara nodded.

“Okay.”

Her voice was barely audible.

She turned around.

Aarav watched her walk away.

Something inside him immediately told him to stop her.

To call her back.

To say sorry.

But his anger was louder.

So he stayed where he was.

Meera looked at him.

“Aarav…”

“Not now.”

She stopped.

He walked away.

The group slowly dispersed.

Nobody knew what to say.

Kiara went toward the opposite side of the campus.

She reached the staircase.

And only when she was alone did she stop.

Her eyes filled with tears.

She wiped them quickly.

She didn't want anyone to see.

Especially Aarav.

She took out her phone.

The screen was filled with missed calls from him.

She stared at them.

For a moment, she almost called him.

Then she locked the phone.

Maybe he needed space.

Maybe she had been too dependent on him.

Maybe he really could live without her.

She walked out of the college gate.

That evening, Aarav sat alone in his room.

His phone was beside him.

He opened his contacts.

His finger stopped at Kiara's name.

He stared at it.

He wanted to call.

But he didn't.

Instead, he opened their chat.

Years of messages were there.

Birthday wishes.

Random jokes.

Photographs.

Arguments.

Apologies.

Plans.

Memories.

He scrolled upward.

Further.

Further.

Until he reached messages from Class 11.

He smiled at one.

Then his smile disappeared.

He locked his phone.

Five minutes later, he opened it again.

Still no message from Kiara.

He told himself he didn't care.

But he kept checking.

Across the city, Kiara sat beside her bedroom window.

Her phone was in her hand.

She opened Aarav's chat.

Typed:

I'm sorry.

Deleted it.

Typed:

Can we talk?

Deleted it.

Typed:

I didn't mean to hurt you.

Deleted that too.

Finally, she put the phone down.

She looked outside.

The city was glowing.

Cars moved through the streets.

People were going home.

Life continued normally.

But for the first time in years, Aarav and Kiara had gone home without speaking to each other.

And neither of them knew what to do next.

They had survived hundreds of small arguments.

They had always come back.

But this time was different.

Because some words don't disappear after they're spoken.

They stay.

They repeat themselves in your mind.

And sometimes, the person who said them doesn't realize how deeply they were heard.

That night, two phones stayed silent.

Two people waited.

Neither apologized.

Neither called.

And somewhere between anger and pride, the friendship that had survived for years took its first real step toward breaking.

The silence had begun.

CHAPTER 7

I Can Live Without You

The next morning felt different.

Not because anything around them had changed.

The college was still crowded.

The corridors were still noisy.

The canteen was still full.

Lectures still started at the same time.

But Aarav noticed something immediately.

Kiara wasn't there.

Usually, she would be waiting near the entrance.

Usually, she would complain that he was late.

Usually, the first thing he heard in the morning was her voice.

Today, there was nothing.

He stood near the gate for a few minutes, pretending he was only waiting for his friends.

He wasn't.

He was waiting for her.

She never came.

During the first lecture, Aarav kept looking toward the empty seat beside him.

It had always been Kiara's seat.

He hadn't realized how much he had gotten used to seeing her there.

The professor was explaining something on the board.

Aarav heard almost none of it.

His phone was on the desk.

No message.

No call.

He opened their chat.

The last message was from two days ago.

He typed:

Are you coming to college?

He stared at it.

Then deleted it.

He locked his phone.

A minute later, he unlocked it again.

Nothing.

He sighed.

Meera noticed.

“You okay?”

“Yeah.”

“You've said that three times today.”

Aarav looked at her.

“I'm fine.”

Meera didn't argue.

She knew when he didn't want to talk.

At lunch, their friends sat together.

But something was missing.

One of them looked around.

“Where's Kiara?”

Nobody answered.

Another friend looked at Aarav.

“You two still fighting?”

Aarav shrugged.

“It's nothing.”

“Bro, yesterday didn't look like nothing.”

“I said it's fine.”

The table became quiet.

Meera looked at him.

She could see the anger was slowly turning into something else.

Regret.

But Aarav wasn't ready to admit it.

One of their friends tried to change the subject.

“So, who's coming for the weekend plan?”

Nobody answered immediately.

It was strange.

Kiara was usually the first person to organize everything.

Without her, even simple plans felt incomplete.

That evening, Aarav finally went home early.

He dropped his bag on the chair and sat on his bed.

His room was quiet.

Too quiet.

He opened his phone.

Still nothing.

He went through their old photographs.

There was one from their first college festival.

One from their Matheran planning day.

One from a café.

One from a random evening when neither of them remembered why they had taken it.

Then he found the photograph from their first year trip.

Aarav was smiling.

Kiara was standing beside him.

They both looked happy.

He stared at it.

Then he remembered her face from the previous day.

The way she had looked at him after he said:

Leave me alone, Kiara.

His stomach tightened.

He whispered to himself,

“I didn't mean it.”

But the room didn't answer.

Across Mumbai, Kiara was sitting in her room.

She had skipped college again.

Her mother asked if she was feeling okay.

She said yes.

She wasn't sick.

She just didn't know how to face Aarav.

Her phone was beside her.

She opened his contact.

Her thumb hovered over the call button.

She almost pressed it.

Then she remembered his voice.

I can live without you.

She locked the phone.

Maybe he meant it.

Maybe she had become too much of his life.

Maybe he wanted to prove that he could be okay without her.

She didn't want to make things worse.

So she stayed silent.

The silence continued.

One day became two.

Two became four.

Then a week.

They stopped talking.

Not because they hated each other.

Because neither knew how to start again.

Their friends tried.

One afternoon, a friend approached Aarav.

“Just talk to her.”

Aarav looked away.

“She doesn't want to talk.”

“How do you know?”

“She hasn't called.”

“Maybe she's waiting for you.”

Aarav didn't answer.

The friend sighed.

“You two have been friends for years. Don't let one argument destroy it.”

Aarav quietly said,

“Maybe it already did.”

Meera heard those words from a distance.

She didn't interrupt.

She knew Aarav was hurting.

But she also knew something else.

He missed Kiara.

A lot.

She could see it in everything he did.

Whenever something funny happened, he would instinctively look to the side as if expecting Kiara to be there.

Whenever he wanted to make plans, he'd start typing her name before stopping himself.

Whenever someone mentioned their old memories, his expression changed.

Meera understood.

She didn't want to become the person who used his loneliness against him.

So she gave him space.

Even though a small part of her wished he would look at her differently.

Two weeks passed.

Aarav and Kiara still hadn't spoken.

Then one evening, Aarav opened his phone and made a decision.

He was going to delete her number.

He stared at the contact for a long time.

He knew the number by heart anyway.

But deleting it felt like admitting something.

That things were different now.

He opened their conversation.

His finger hovered over the screen.

Then he deleted the chat.

Photographs remained in his gallery.

He couldn't delete those.

Not yet.

Across the city, Kiara was doing the same thing.

She opened Aarav's contact.

She stared at his name.

Then she deleted it.

She opened their chat.

Years of messages.

She looked at them one last time.

Then deleted the conversation.

She put her phone down.

And cried quietly.

Not because she wanted to forget him.

But because she didn't know how to keep someone in her life when they had asked her to leave.

The following Monday, Kiara finally returned to college.

Aarav saw her from across the corridor.

Their eyes met.

For a moment, neither moved.

Years of friendship stood between them.

So did one terrible sentence.

Kiara looked away first.

Aarav wanted to say something.

Anything.

But his pride stopped him.

She walked past him.

No greeting.

No smile.

Nothing.

Aarav watched her disappear into the classroom.

He felt a strange emptiness.

The kind he couldn't explain.

He had always believed that people could walk away and you could simply move on.

But this wasn't someone.

This was Kiara.

His best friend.

The person who had been there since Class 9.

The person who knew him better than almost anyone.

And now she was walking past him like a stranger.

That night, Aarav sat on his balcony.

The city was alive beneath him.

He thought about the promise they had made on that hill.

No matter what happens, don't let one bad day destroy everything.

He closed his eyes.

He remembered saying,

“Promise.”

He wished he could go back.

Just for a minute.

Just long enough to choose different words.

But life doesn't work that way.

You can regret a sentence.

You can wish you had stayed quiet.

You can wish you had called.

But once the moment passes, all you can do is live with what you said.

Aarav looked at his phone.

There was no Kiara's name anymore.

He whispered,

“I can live without you.”

But this time, it didn't sound like confidence.

It sounded like a lie he was trying to convince himself to believe.

And somewhere else in Mumbai, Kiara was trying to do the same.

Neither knew that their silence was about to become much bigger than an argument.

Neither knew that soon, they wouldn't even have the chance to choose whether to speak.

CHAPTER 8

Silence

Silence has a strange way of becoming normal.

At first, you notice it.

Then you get used to it.

And eventually, you forget what it felt like before.

That was what happened to Aarav and Kiara.

After their argument, they stopped talking.

Not for a day.

Not for a week.

Long enough for the silence to become part of their routine.

Aarav still went to college every morning.

He still attended lectures.

He still sat with the group.

He still laughed when someone told a joke.

From the outside, nothing seemed wrong.

But everyone who knew him could tell.

He wasn't the same.

He had become quieter.

He stopped staying after lectures.

He stopped making weekend plans.

He stopped taking random photographs.

Even his phone seemed quieter.

There were no messages from Kiara.

No calls.

No stupid memes.

No:

Where are you?

No:

Come to the canteen.

No:

You won't believe what just happened.

Nothing.

And strangely, the absence of those little messages hurt more than the argument itself.

Meera noticed everything.

One afternoon, she sat beside Aarav in the library.

“You haven't spoken much today.”

“I'm studying.”

“You've been staring at the same page for ten minutes.”

Aarav looked down.

He hadn't even realized.

He smiled faintly.

“Maybe it's an interesting page.”

Meera smiled.

“Very interesting.”

Aarav laughed quietly.

It was the first real laugh she'd heard from him in days.

She didn't ask about Kiara.

She knew he didn't want to talk about it.

Instead, she pushed her notebook toward him.

“Help me with this.”

Aarav looked at the question.

“This is easy.”

“Then explain it.”

He started explaining.

For the next fifteen minutes, they talked about the assignment.

Nothing emotional.

Nothing complicated.

Just normal.

And for those fifteen minutes, Aarav forgot about everything else.

Meera noticed.

She smiled to herself.

She wasn't trying to fix him.

She was simply giving him a reason to stop thinking for a while.

Meanwhile, Kiara had changed too.

She still attended college.

She still talked to people.

But she avoided places where she might run into Aarav alone.

If he entered the canteen, she left.

If he walked into the library, she found another table.

If their friends made plans, she asked whether Aarav was coming before deciding.

Nobody knew what to do.

They had become two people moving around the same college, deliberately avoiding each other.

One afternoon, one of their friends finally lost patience.

“This is ridiculous.”

Aarav looked up.

“What?”

“You both are.”

“I'm not doing anything.”

“Exactly.”

Aarav frowned.

“What do you want me to do?”

“Talk to her.”

Aarav looked away.

“She doesn't want to talk to me.”

“How do you know?”

“She deleted my number.”

The friend became quiet.

“You deleted hers too.”

Aarav didn't respond.

“Then both of you are idiots.”

Aarav almost smiled.

“Probably.”

A few days later, the group had a small college event.

Everyone was expected to attend.

Aarav arrived early.

Kiara arrived later.

They noticed each other.

Neither said anything.

Meera was standing nearby.

She watched them.

There was no anger anymore.

At least, not obvious anger.

There was something worse.

Distance.

Aarav looked at Kiara as if he wanted to say something.

Kiara looked at him for a second.

Then she looked away.

The event continued.

Music played.

People laughed.

Pictures were taken.

Everyone seemed happy.

But Aarav and Kiara stayed on opposite sides of the room.

At one point, the group gathered for a photograph.

Someone shouted,

“Come on! Everyone together!”

Aarav stood at one side.

Kiara stood at the other.

Meera stood between them.

The camera flashed.

For a moment, all three were in the same frame.

Aarav looked at the photograph afterward.

Meera was smiling.

Kiara was smiling too.

But he could see something in her eyes.

Something tired.

He put the phone away.

That night, Aarav opened his gallery.

He found hundreds of old photographs.

He started scrolling.

Class 9.

Class 10.

School trips.

Birthdays.

College admissions.

First day at St. Aurelia.

Their first-year trip.

The three of them.

He stopped at one photograph.

Aarav and Kiara were standing beside each other.

She was laughing.

He was looking at her.

The photograph had captured a moment neither of them had noticed.

He stared at it for a long time.

Then he whispered,

“I'm sorry.”

It was the first time he had said it aloud.

But Kiara wasn't there to hear it.

The next morning, Aarav almost called her.

He opened the contact list.

Her name wasn't there.

He had deleted it.

He searched through old messages.

Nothing.

He knew he could get her number from someone else.

But something stopped him.

Pride.

Fear.

Or maybe both.

He put the phone away.

He told himself,

“Maybe it's better this way.”

But he didn't believe it.

Kiara was having the same thoughts.

She sat in the back of a classroom before everyone arrived.

She opened her notebook.

A small piece of paper fell out.

It was an old note from Aarav.

Nothing important.

Just a reminder about an assignment from their first year.

She smiled when she saw it.

Then her eyes became wet.

She folded it carefully and placed it back inside the notebook.

She missed him.

She missed their conversations.

She missed their arguments.

She even missed him annoying her.

But she couldn't forget what he had said.

I can live without you.

Maybe he could.

Maybe he was already learning how.

Weeks turned into months.

The distance became permanent.

Their friends eventually stopped trying to force them to talk.

Life moved forward.

Classes continued.

Assignments piled up.

Exams arrived.

Mumbai stayed loud and busy.

But for Aarav, something remained strangely quiet.

He had people around him.

But the one person he used to tell everything to was gone.

And he didn't know how to replace that space.

He didn't even want to.

Then, one ordinary afternoon, something happened that Aarav didn't know about.

Kiara was on her way home.

Her phone was in her hand.

There were no messages from Aarav.

There hadn't been for months.

She looked at his old photograph in her gallery.

She smiled sadly.

Then she locked her phone.

She had no idea that this would be one of the last normal moments of her old life.

A few hours later, everything would change.

Not because she chose to leave Aarav.

Not because she wanted to hurt him.

But because sometimes life makes decisions for people before they even realize a decision has been made.

And this time, Aarav wouldn't know the truth.

Not for a very long time.

CHAPTER 9

The Accident

It happened on an ordinary evening.

The kind of evening that never feels important while you're living it.

Kiara had left college a little later than usual.

The sky was cloudy, and Mumbai was already beginning to fill with evening traffic.

She walked toward the parking area with her phone in her hand.

There were several unread messages from the group.

She looked at them briefly.

Then she opened her gallery.

A photograph appeared on the screen.

Aarav.

She stopped walking.

It was an old picture from their first year.

Both of them were laughing.

She stared at it for a few seconds.

A small smile appeared on her face.

Then she locked the phone.

“Enough,” she whispered to herself.

She had spent months thinking about whether she should talk to him.

Maybe she should.

Maybe she shouldn't.

Maybe one day they would finally sit down and talk about everything.

She didn't know.

But somewhere inside, she still believed that one day they would.

They had been best friends for years.

People didn't simply become strangers forever.

At least, that was what she wanted to believe.

Kiara left the college area.

The roads were busy.

The rain had started lightly.

She kept her attention on the road.

Her phone was inside her bag.

For once, she wasn't thinking about messages.

She wasn't thinking about Aarav.

She was simply going home.

Then, in a moment that changed everything, another vehicle came too close.

Kiara tried to react.

There was a sudden impact.

Her phone slipped from her bag.

Everything became confusing.

People stopped nearby.

Someone called for help.

Someone else contacted her family.

Kiara was taken to a hospital.

Her phone remained behind, damaged and unusable.

And nobody who knew Aarav knew what had happened.

That same evening, Aarav was sitting with Meera and a few friends at a café.

Someone was telling a joke.

Everyone laughed.

Aarav smiled.

For the first time in a long time, he seemed slightly more like himself.

Meera noticed.

She was happy for him.

Then one of their friends received a call.

His expression changed.

“What happened?” Meera asked.

He didn't answer immediately.

He looked at his phone again.

Then said,

“Nothing. Just something with someone from college.”

Aarav barely paid attention.

He had no idea that the person they were talking about was Kiara.

No one at the table knew either.

At the hospital, Kiara's family waited outside.

The doctors were taking care of her.

She was safe, but she needed time to recover.

Her mother held her belongings.

Her phone was badly damaged.

The screen wouldn't turn on.

Her contacts were inaccessible.

Her messages were gone.

Her photographs were gone.

Everything stored on it was suddenly unreachable.

Including Aarav's number.

But that wasn't the biggest problem.

Even if she had remembered his number, she didn't know whether he would want to hear from her.

After all, the last thing he had said to her was:

Leave me alone, Kiara.

She had respected his words.

She didn't know he had regretted them almost immediately.

The next morning, Aarav went to college.

He walked through the gate.

For some reason, he looked toward the entrance.

He didn't know why.

Kiara wasn't there.

She hadn't been there for a while anyway.

So he continued walking.

Meera joined him.

“Morning.”

“Morning.”

“You seem better today.”

“Maybe.”

She smiled.

“That's good.”

They entered the classroom.

Aarav took his seat.

Another normal day began.

He didn't know that Kiara was in a hospital.

He didn't know that her phone had been destroyed.

He didn't know that the silence between them had now become something neither of them had chosen.

He only knew that she hadn't contacted him.

And somewhere deep inside, he assumed that was her decision.

A few days passed.

Then a week.

Then another.

Kiara's family decided she needed to stay away from college for a while.

There were family matters to handle.

There were recovery arrangements.

There were conversations about temporarily leaving Mumbai.

Everything happened quickly.

Too quickly.

Kiara wanted to return to college.

She wanted to fix things.

She wanted to talk to Aarav.

But every time she thought about it, she remembered his last words.

Maybe he really didn't want her around anymore.

Maybe the accident had happened at the worst possible time.

Maybe life had simply moved them in different directions.

She didn't know.

And Aarav knew even less.

One evening, Aarav sat alone in his room.

He opened his phone.

He still had no message from Kiara.

He stared at the screen.

Then he laughed bitterly.

“She really meant it.”

He didn't know that she hadn't chosen silence.

He didn't know she couldn't reach him.

He didn't know that while he was waiting for an apology, she was dealing with something completely different.

He put the phone down.

For the first time, he stopped expecting her to come back.

And that was the moment the misunderstanding became deeper.

Meanwhile, Kiara stood near a window at home.

She looked outside at the Mumbai skyline.

She had spent years imagining her future here.

College.

Friends.

Aarav.

Everything.

Now she wasn't sure what would happen next.

Her mother came into the room.

“We may have to leave Mumbai for some time.”

Kiara was quiet.

“Okay.”

“You can come back when things are better.”

Kiara nodded.

She looked at the city one last time.

There were so many memories here.

Her first day of college.

The canteen.

The trips.

The evenings with Aarav.

The promise on the hill.

And the last argument.

She closed her eyes.

She didn't know when she would return.

She didn't know what Aarav would think.

She didn't know whether their friendship could ever be repaired.

But somewhere inside, she still hoped that one day they would meet again.

And when that day came, she would finally tell him the truth.

Back at college, Aarav was learning how to live without her.

He didn't know that he wasn't actually being left behind.

He didn't know that the person he believed had chosen to disappear had never made that choice.

He only knew that the person he couldn't imagine losing was gone.

And for the first time, he had no idea when—or if—she would come back.

The truth was still far away.

For now, all Aarav had was silence.

And silence, when you don't know the truth, can make you believe almost anything.

CHAPTER 10

Too Late

A few weeks passed.

Then a few more.

Life at St. Aurelia College continued as if nothing had happened.

Classes.

Assignments.

Exams.

Canteen conversations.

College events.

Everything moved forward.

But Aarav didn't.

Not completely.

There was a part of him that was still standing at the college gate, waiting for Kiara to appear.

He never admitted it.

Not to his friends.

Not to Meera.

Not even to himself.

One afternoon, Aarav was sitting in the canteen with the group.

Someone was talking about an upcoming college event.

“We need to decide who is handling the decorations.”

Aarav looked around.

“Kiara would know.”

The table became quiet.

He immediately realized what he had said.

His friend looked at him.

“You still think about her.”

Aarav looked down.

“I was just saying.”

Nobody replied.

Meera quietly changed the subject.

“Who is handling the music?”

The conversation continued.

But Aarav wasn't listening anymore.

He was thinking about how naturally he had said her name.

As if she were still sitting beside him.

As if nothing had changed.

That evening, Aarav went to the place where he and Kiara had once watched the sunset.

The hill outside Mumbai.

The same bench.

The same city lights.

But this time, he was alone.

He sat down.

For a while, he simply looked at the skyline.

Then he took out his phone.

He opened his gallery.

The old photographs were still there.

He found one from that evening.

Kiara was standing beside him.

She was smiling at the camera.

He remembered what she had said.

No matter what happens between us, don't let one bad day destroy everything.

Aarav closed his eyes.

“I broke the promise.”

His voice was quiet.

He sat there for a long time.

Then he finally admitted something he had been avoiding.

He missed her.

Not because he was lonely.

Not because he had no other friends.

He missed *her*.

Her voice.

Her jokes.

Her random calls.

Her arguments.

The way she understood him without asking.

He missed having someone who knew his life from the beginning.

And suddenly, the anger he had carried for months felt small.

Very small.

Aarav took out a piece of paper from his bag.

He had started writing something for himself.

Not to send.

Just to say what he couldn't say aloud.

He wrote:

I was angry.

I said things I didn't mean.

I thought you didn't care.

But maybe I was the one who stopped caring about what you were feeling.

He paused.

Then continued.

I'm sorry.

He folded the paper.

He didn't know where to send it.

He didn't have her number.

He didn't know where she was.

So he kept it.

The next day, Aarav asked one of their classmates,

“Have you heard from Kiara?”

The friend shook his head.

“No.”

“Do you know where she is?”

“No. I thought she left college.”

Aarav frowned.

“Why?”

“Family reasons, I think.”

“Did she say anything?”

“No.”

Aarav nodded.

“Okay.”

He walked away.

But this time, something felt different.

For months, he had assumed Kiara had simply chosen to leave him.

Now he wasn't so sure.

He went to the college office.

He asked if there was any information about her.

The staff member checked the records.

“She's currently on leave.”

“Do you know when she'll return?”

“I'm not sure.”

Aarav nodded.

“Okay. Thank you.”

He walked out.

For the first time, he had a small piece of hope.

She hadn't officially left.

She was simply away.

Maybe she would return.

Maybe they would talk.

Maybe everything could still be fixed.

But days passed.

Then weeks.

She didn't return.

Aarav started accepting that she might be gone for a long time.

His life slowly changed.

He spent more time with Meera.

Not because he was trying to forget Kiara.

Meera simply stayed.

She never demanded explanations.

She never asked Aarav to stop thinking about Kiara.

She never said,

“I'm better for you.”

She never tried to take Kiara's place.

She just became his friend.

One afternoon, they were walking out of college when Meera said,

“You know, you don't have to pretend you're okay around me.”

Aarav looked at her.

“I know.”

“You can talk about her.”

He was quiet.

“You don't mind?”

Meera shook her head.

“No.”

Aarav smiled faintly.

“Thank you.”

Meera smiled.

“Friends are allowed to listen.”

That sentence stayed with him.

A few days later, Aarav finally talked.

They were sitting at Marine Drive.

The sea was calm.

The city was loud behind them.

“I miss her,” Aarav said.

Meera looked at him.

“I know.”

“I thought I was angry.”

“You were.”

“But now I'm just tired.”

Meera didn't interrupt.

Aarav continued.

“She was my best friend for years. I can't just forget everything because of one fight.”

“You don't have to.”

He looked at the sea.

“I wish I had called her.”

Meera quietly said,

“Maybe one day you will.”

Aarav smiled sadly.

“Maybe.”

Neither of them knew how true that would become.

That night, Aarav went home and opened the old photograph again.

He stared at Kiara's face.

For months, he had believed she had chosen to walk away.

But now he wondered whether there was another explanation.

Maybe she was dealing with something.

Maybe she was hurt.

Maybe she was waiting for him.

He didn't know.

And that uncertainty was harder than anger.

Because anger gives you someone to blame.

Not knowing gives you nothing.

Aarav placed his phone on the table.

He whispered,

“If you're somewhere out there, Kiara…”

He stopped.

Then smiled sadly.

“I hope you're okay.”

Far away from Mumbai, Kiara was looking at an old photograph too.

A photograph of three friends.

Aarav.

Kiara.

Meera.

She smiled when she saw it.

Then her eyes filled with tears.

She wondered whether Aarav still remembered her.

Whether he hated her.

Whether he had moved on.

Whether he ever thought about the promises they had made.

She didn't know.

But she still hoped.

Someday.

Somewhere.

They would meet again.

And when they did, she would finally explain everything.

Until then, life had to continue.

For both of them.

Aarav didn't know the truth yet.

He only knew one thing.

Some people can leave your life without leaving your heart.

And Kiara had become exactly that.

The person he couldn't forget.

But while Aarav was learning to live with her absence, someone else was quietly becoming a part of his everyday life.

Someone who had never tried to replace Kiara.

Someone who simply stayed.

Meera.

And soon, Aarav would begin to notice how much her presence had started to matter.

CHAPTER 11

Three Months Later

Three months had passed.

Three months since Aarav and Kiara had stopped talking.

At first, Aarav had believed it would last a few days.

Then a week.

Then maybe a month.

He kept thinking that one of them would eventually give in.

One of them would call.

One of them would send a message.

One of them would simply say, *“Enough. Let's talk.”*

But nothing happened.

And slowly, Aarav stopped waiting.

Not because he stopped caring.

Because waiting had started hurting too much.

College was still the same.

The same corridors.

The same canteen.

The same classrooms.

The same group of friends laughing over things that weren't even funny.

But Aarav wasn't the same.

He still came to college every day, attended classes, submitted assignments, answered professors when they asked him questions.

From the outside, everything looked normal.

But his friends noticed.

He no longer stayed in the canteen for hours.

He stopped joining spontaneous plans.

He stopped being the first person to suggest a movie or a trip.

Even when everyone laughed, he sometimes smiled a few seconds late, as if his mind was somewhere else.

And there were certain things he couldn't do anymore.

He couldn't sit at their usual table without remembering Kiara sitting across from him.

He couldn't walk past the college gate without remembering the hundreds of times they had left together.

And whenever someone casually mentioned the word *best friend*, his expression changed for just a second.

Most people didn't notice.

Meera did.

She had noticed it for weeks.

At first, she didn't ask.

She knew that some sadness needed space before it needed questions.

One afternoon, she was sitting with a few classmates in the canteen when Aarav walked past them.

He gave everyone a small smile.

“I'm going to class.”

“There's still twenty minutes,” one of his friends said.

“I know.”

“You're seriously going to study?”

Aarav smiled faintly.

“Trying to.”

And he walked away.

Meera watched him disappear down the corridor.

She turned toward his friends.

“What happened to him?”

One of them looked at her.

“You don't know?”

Meera shook her head.

“I know about Kiara. But I don't know exactly what happened.”

The table became quiet.

For a moment, nobody answered.

Then one of his friends sighed.

“They had a huge fight.”

“What kind of fight?”

“I don't even know everything. Kiara wasn't answering his calls that day. Aarav got angry. The next day they argued.”

Meera listened carefully.

“And then?”

“He said something like he could live without her.”

Meera's expression changed.

“And Kiara?”

“She started crying.”

Meera looked down.

“He told her to leave him alone.”

Nobody said anything for a few seconds.

“And after that?” she asked quietly.

“They stopped talking.”

“Completely?”

“Completely.”

Meera slowly looked toward the corridor where Aarav had disappeared.

She finally understood.

It wasn't just that Aarav had lost contact with his best friend.

He thought he had lost her because she chose to leave.

And somewhere inside him, he was still blaming himself for letting anger speak for him.

“Does he know where she is?” Meera asked.

“I don't think so. She's been away for a long time.”

Meera nodded.

She didn't ask anything else.

That evening, she found Aarav sitting alone outside the classroom.

His notebook was open.

But he wasn't writing.

He was staring at the same page.

“Hey,” Meera said.

Aarav looked up.

“Oh. Hey.”

She sat beside him.

“What are you doing?”

“Studying.”

She looked at the completely blank page.

“Very productive.”

Aarav smiled.

“I'm thinking.”

“About?”

“Nothing.”

Meera raised an eyebrow.

“You're terrible at lying.”

He laughed softly.

“I've heard that before.”

For a moment, they sat quietly.

Meera wanted to ask about Kiara.

She wanted to tell him that she knew.

But she stopped herself.

Instead, she said,

“You know you don't have to pretend you're okay around me.”

Aarav looked at her.

“I know.”

“You don't?”

“I do.”

“Then why do you?”

He looked away.

“Because I don't want everyone to keep asking me what's wrong.”

Meera nodded.

“Fair enough.”

She stood up.

“Come on.”

“Where?”

“Canteen.”

“I'm not hungry.”

“I didn't ask if you were hungry.”

He looked at her, confused.

“Then why are we going?”

“Because I'm hungry.”

Aarav laughed.

“You're impossible.”

“I know.”

He closed his notebook and stood up.

That was how it started.

Not with a big conversation.

Not with Meera trying to fix him.

Just small moments.

A walk to the canteen.

A stupid joke during class.

A meme sent at midnight.

A message asking if he'd finished an assignment.

A random conversation about movies.

Sometimes they talked for hours.

Sometimes they barely spoke.

And Meera never once asked Aarav to forget Kiara.

She understood something important.

She couldn't replace a person who had been part of his life for years.

And she didn't want to.

She just wanted Aarav to know that someone was still there.

A few days later, Aarav was sitting alone on the college steps when Meera walked over.

“You're going somewhere?”

“No.”

“You look like you're going somewhere.”

Aarav smiled.

“Maybe my face is confused.”

Meera sat beside him.

“Do you miss her?”

Aarav didn't answer immediately.

He looked toward the college entrance.

Then he quietly said,

“Every day.”

Meera nodded.

“Then miss her.”

Aarav looked at her.

“What?”

“You don't have to stop.”

He stared at her for a moment.

“Most people tell me to move on.”

“I'm not most people.”

A small smile appeared on his face.

“No. You're not.”

Meera looked ahead.

“You cared about her. A lot. Maybe you still do. That's okay.”

Aarav lowered his eyes.

“I just wish I knew what happened.”

“Maybe one day you'll know.”

“And if I don't?”

Meera thought for a moment.

“Then you'll still have to keep living.”

Aarav smiled faintly.

“You make everything sound simple.”

“No,” she said. “I just don't think everything has to be solved today.”

He looked at her.

For the first time in a long time, Aarav felt like someone understood without asking him to explain every detail.

That night, he went home and opened his phone.

There was still no message from Kiara.

He stared at her old contact for a few seconds.

Then he locked the phone.

He didn't know where she was.

He didn't know if she missed him.

He didn't know if she was angry.

He didn't know if they would ever speak again.

But for the first time, he didn't spend the entire night waiting.

He simply put the phone aside.

The next morning, Meera saw him entering college.

“You look different,” she said.

“Different how?”

“Less dead.”

Aarav laughed.

“That's your compliment?”

“Take it.”

He shook his head.

“You're weird.”

“And you're smiling.”

He stopped.

He hadn't even realized it.

Then he smiled again.

“Maybe.”

Meera smiled back.

Neither of them knew it yet.

But something had begun.

Not love.

Not yet.

Just a friendship.

The kind that quietly enters your life when you're not looking for anyone.

The kind that doesn't ask you to forget yesterday.

The kind that simply sits beside you while you try to survive today.

And somewhere between the empty spaces Kiara had left behind and the small moments Meera was filling with laughter, Aarav was slowly beginning to feel like himself again.

But there was still one place he went whenever his thoughts became too loud.

The beach.

And Meera would soon find him there.

CHAPTER 12

The Boy at the Beach

Mumbai had a way of making loneliness look ordinary.

Millions of people moved through the city every day.

Trains were crowded.

Roads were noisy.

Cafés were full.

The streets never seemed to sleep.

And yet, sometimes, one person could feel completely alone in the middle of all of it.

Aarav had started going to the beach whenever that feeling became too heavy.

He never told anyone.

He would simply leave college, ride for a while, and sit near the water.

No friends.

No music.

No phone calls.

Just the sound of the waves.

That evening, the sky was slowly turning orange.

Aarav sat on the sand, his knees pulled slightly toward himself.

Beside him was an unopened bottle of beer that he had bought without really thinking.

He wasn't drinking it.

He wasn't even interested in it.

It was simply sitting there.

His phone was in his hand.

He unlocked it.

Opened his contacts.

Scrolled.

Stopped.

Kiara's name was no longer there.

He had deleted it months ago.

For a second, he wished he hadn't.

Then he locked his phone again.

“Why do you always come here?”

Aarav looked up.

Meera stood a few steps away.

He blinked.

“What are you doing here?”

“I could ask you the same thing.”

“I come here sometimes.”

“I noticed.”

Aarav looked surprised.

“You noticed?”

“You disappear after college sometimes.”

He smiled slightly.

“You were keeping track?”

“Don't flatter yourself.”

She sat down beside him.

For a few seconds, neither spoke.

The waves moved toward the shore and disappeared again.

Meera looked at the bottle beside him.

Then at him.

“You're not drinking that, are you?”

Aarav looked down.

“No.”

“Good.”

“I wasn't planning to.”

“I know.”

She paused.

“Then why is it here?”

Aarav shrugged.

“Didn't think about it.”

Meera nodded and left the subject there.

She didn't lecture him.

She didn't make assumptions.

She simply looked at the sea.

“It's peaceful here.”

“That's why I come.”

“You think too much?”

“All the time.”

“I knew it.”

Aarav smiled.

“What's that supposed to mean?”

“You have the face of someone who has twenty conversations happening inside his head.”

He laughed quietly.

“That's oddly accurate.”

They sat there for a while.

The sun slowly disappeared.

The sky became darker.

The city lights began appearing behind them.

Meera finally asked,

“Do you come here because of her?”

Aarav knew exactly who she meant.

He didn't answer immediately.

“Yes.”

Meera looked at him.

“You don't have to talk about it.”

“I know.”

He took a breath.

“I just don't know what I'm supposed to do.”

“With what?”

“With everything.”

He looked toward the water.

“I keep thinking that if I had just stayed calm that day, maybe things would be different.”

Meera listened.

“I said things I shouldn't have said.”

“You were angry.”

“I know.”

“You're allowed to be angry.”

“But I wasn't allowed to hurt her.”

Meera didn't disagree.

Aarav continued.

“She was my best friend. Since school. We were supposed to be in each other's lives. We had plans.”

“What kind of plans?”

“Everything.”

He smiled sadly.

“Trips. Graduation. Jobs. We'd joke about growing old and still annoying each other.”

Meera smiled.

“She sounds important.”

“She was.”

A pause.

“She is.”

Meera looked at him.

Aarav corrected himself quietly.

“She is important.”

The words stayed between them.

Meera didn't try to change them.

Instead, she said,

“Then don't force yourself to forget her.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Why are you always saying that?”

“Because I don't think forgetting someone is the same thing as moving forward.”

He was silent.

Meera continued.

“You can miss someone and still make new memories.”

Aarav looked at her for a long moment.

“Why do you care so much?”

Meera smiled.

“Because you're my friend.”

“That's it?”

“For now.”

He laughed.

“For now?”

“Don't make it dramatic.”

“I'm not.”

“You are.”

He shook his head.

For the first time that evening, his smile looked genuine.

Meera noticed.

She didn't say anything.

She simply smiled too.

The two of them stayed there until the sky became completely dark.

They talked about random things.

College.

Professors.

Their worst school memories.

Movies.

Food.

Places they wanted to visit.

At one point, Meera asked,

“If you could go anywhere tomorrow, where would you go?”

Aarav thought.

“Somewhere quiet.”

“That's boring.”

“You asked.”

“Okay. Somewhere exciting?”

“Matheran.”

“Why Matheran?”

“I've always wanted to go.”

Meera smiled.

“Then let's go someday.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Just us?”

She immediately laughed.

“No. With everyone.”

“Right.”

“You looked disappointed.”

“I did not.”

“You did.”

“I didn't.”

She laughed again.

For a few minutes, everything felt normal.

No Kiara.

No fight.

No unanswered questions.

Just two friends sitting by the sea.

Eventually, Meera stood up.

“We should go.”

Aarav nodded.

He picked up the unopened bottle and placed it in a nearby bin.

Meera noticed.

“Good.”

Aarav looked at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

They started walking toward the road.

After a few steps, Meera stopped.

“Aarav.”

“Hmm?”

“You don't have to handle everything alone.”

He looked at her.

She continued,

“If you ever need someone to talk to, call me.”

Aarav smiled.

“I don't have your number.”

Meera stared at him.

“Seriously?”

“You never gave it to me.”

She took out her phone.

“Give me yours.”

He handed it over.

She typed her number into his phone.

Then called herself.

Her phone rang.

She saved his contact.

“What should I save your name as?”

“Aarav.”

“Too boring.”

“It's my name.”

“Exactly.”

She thought for a moment.

Then smiled.

“Aarav — Overthinker.”

He laughed.

“Absolutely not.”

“Too late.”

He took her phone.

“Then I'm saving you as Meera — Annoying.”

“Excuse me?”

“You started it.”

She tried to take her phone back.

“Delete that!”

“No.”

“Aarav!”

He laughed as he walked away.

“Goodnight, Annoying.”

She followed him.

“Goodnight, Overthinker!”

And for the first time in months, Aarav went home without feeling like the night was something he had to survive.

He had someone to call now.

Someone to laugh with.

Someone who didn't ask him to forget the past.

Someone who simply stayed.

And neither of them knew it yet—

but that new number in Aarav's phone was going to change his life.

CHAPTER 13

A New Number

The next morning, Aarav woke up to a message.

Meera — Annoying: *Good morning, Overthinker.*

Aarav stared at the screen.

Then smiled.

He typed a reply.

Aarav — Overthinker: *It's 7:12 in the morning. Why are you already annoying me?*

Her reply came almost immediately.

Meera — Annoying: *Because I have talent.*

Aarav laughed.

He put his phone down and got ready for college.

It was a small thing.

Just two messages.

But it had been a long time since someone had given him a reason to smile first thing in the morning.

At college, Meera was already waiting near the entrance.

“You're late.”

Aarav checked his watch.

“I'm two minutes early.”

“Still late.”

“You're impossible.”

“I know.”

They walked toward their classroom together.

Their friendship slowly became a routine.

Not an official one.

Neither of them ever sat down and decided they would become best friends.

It simply happened.

Meera started sending him random memes during lectures.

Aarav started sending her pictures of terrible food from the canteen.

She would complain whenever he ignored her messages.

He would pretend he hadn't seen them.

She would call him.

He would answer laughing.

And somehow, ordinary days became less ordinary.

One afternoon, Meera walked into the classroom holding two cold drinks.

She placed one on Aarav's desk.

“For you.”

He looked at it.

“Why?”

“Because you look tired.”

“I'm always tired.”

“Exactly.”

Aarav smiled.

“Thanks.”

She sat beside him.

“You're welcome.”

He took a sip.

“By the way, you owe me.”

“For what?”

“You made me laugh yesterday.”

“And?”

“I had to stay awake for an assignment.”

Meera stared at him.

“That makes absolutely no sense.”

“I know.”

She laughed.

Their friends began noticing.

One day at lunch, one of them looked at Aarav and said,

“You're finally talking again.”

Aarav looked confused.

“What?”

“You barely spoke to anyone for months.”

Another friend added,

“Now you're always with Meera.”

Meera immediately said,

“Don't start.”

The friend smiled.

“I'm just saying.”

Aarav shook his head.

“She's my friend.”

“Yeah, yeah.”

Meera rolled her eyes.

“Can everyone please eat?”

Everyone laughed.

Aarav smiled.

But for a second, he remembered Kiara.

She would have made the same joke.

She would have laughed louder than everyone else.

She would have probably teased him for getting defensive.

The smile on his face faded slightly.

Meera noticed.

She didn't ask him what was wrong.

Instead, she pushed a packet of fries toward him.

“Eat.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Why?”

“Because you're thinking again.”

He smiled.

“How do you always know?”

“Your face tells me everything.”

He took a fry.

“That's dangerous.”

“Very.”

A few weeks passed.

Aarav and Meera became closer.

They studied together.

Walked home together sometimes.

Stayed back after lectures.

Joined group outings.

Argued about which movies were actually good.

Meera loved romantic movies.

Aarav preferred thrillers.

She called his taste boring.

He called hers predictable.

Neither ever agreed.

One evening, they were sitting in the library.

Meera was studying seriously.

Aarav was staring at the same page for ten minutes.

She finally looked at him.

“Are you studying?”

“Yes.”

“What have you read?”

“Everything.”

“What does the first line say?”

Aarav looked at the page.

He had no idea.

Meera laughed.

“You're hopeless.”

“You distracted me.”

“I've been silent for twenty minutes.”

“Exactly. Suspicious.”

She shook her head.

“You really are an overthinker.”

Aarav smiled.

Then his phone vibrated.

He looked down.

For a second, his heart jumped.

But it wasn't Kiara.

It was a message from Meera.

Meera: *Look up.*

Aarav looked across the table.

She was smiling.

He stared at the message, then at her.

“You're sitting right in front of me.”

“I know.”

“Then why text me?”

“Because it's fun.”

Aarav laughed.

“You're ridiculous.”

“And you're smiling.”

He looked away.

“Maybe.”

That evening, after they left college, Meera asked,

“Do you ever think about what would have happened if you and Kiara never fought?”

Aarav stopped walking.

The question wasn't unexpected.

But it still hurt.

“Sometimes.”

“What do you think?”

“I don't know.”

He looked at the road ahead.

“Maybe we'd still be the same.”

“Maybe.”

“Maybe we'd be closer.”

“Maybe.”

“Maybe we'd never speak again.”

Meera looked at him.

“And what do you want?”

Aarav thought for a long time.

“I want to know the truth.”

“About what happened?”

“Yes.”

He looked down.

“Not because I want everything to go back to how it was.”

Meera listened.

“I just want to know if she really wanted to leave.”

Meera nodded.

“I hope you find out.”

Aarav looked at her.

“You really mean that?”

“Of course.”

“Even if the answer changes things?”

Meera smiled softly.

“Even then.”

That answer stayed with him.

Because Meera wasn't trying to keep him for herself.

She genuinely wanted him to be okay.

And Aarav didn't know why, but that meant more to him than he could explain.

That night, Aarav was lying on his bed.

His phone was beside him.

He opened his contacts.

There were two names that mattered more than most.

One was missing.

One was new.

Meera — Annoying.

He smiled.

Then he opened their chat.

Hundreds of messages had already filled it.

Memes.

Jokes.

Arguments.

Random questions.

College complaints.

Photos of food.

Nothing important.

And yet, somehow, everything felt important.

He typed:

Thanks.

Then deleted it.

Typed again:

Thanks for being there.

Deleted that too.

Finally, he sent:

Aarav: *Goodnight.*

Her reply came a minute later.

Meera: *Goodnight, Overthinker. Don't think too much.*

Aarav smiled at the screen.

Aarav: *No promises.*

He put the phone down.

For the first time in months, silence didn't feel empty.

It felt peaceful.

And somewhere between one ordinary message and another, Meera had become part of his everyday life.

Not as a replacement.

Not as an escape.

Just as herself.

Meera.

The girl with the annoying messages.

The girl who made him laugh.

The girl who stayed.

And Aarav had no idea how important that new number would become.

CHAPTER 14

Somehow, She Made Him Laugh

There are some people who enter your life loudly.

They announce themselves.

They demand your attention.

And then there are people who enter quietly.

They sit beside you.

They listen.

They make you laugh when you didn't feel like smiling.

And one day, you suddenly realize you can't remember what your days were like before them.

For Aarav, Meera had become that person.

It happened slowly.

Almost without him noticing.

Monday morning.

Aarav walked into class and found Meera sitting in his usual seat.

He stopped.

“That's my seat.”

Meera looked up.

“Not anymore.”

“Why?”

“Because I came first.”

“I always sit here.”

“Then today is character development.”

Aarav laughed.

“Move.”

“No.”

“Meera.”

“Aarav.”

“Move.”

“No.”

He pulled the chair beside her and sat down.

She smiled.

“See? Problem solved.”

“You're annoying.”

“You say that every day.”

“Because it's true.”

She smiled.

“And yet you still sit with me.”

Aarav didn't have an answer.

So he opened his notebook.

Their friendship became a collection of little things.

Meera started stealing fries from his plate.

Aarav started taking the last piece of chocolate from hers.

She complained about professors.

He pretended to listen seriously.

He sent her terrible jokes.

She sent him even worse ones.

Sometimes they would sit together without talking at all.

And somehow, the silence wasn't uncomfortable.

One afternoon, Meera sent him a message during class.

Meera: *Look at Professor.*

Aarav looked toward the front.

The professor was writing something on the board.

Aarav: *What?*

Meera: *Look at his handwriting.*

Aarav looked again.

It was barely readable.

He covered his mouth to stop himself from laughing.

The professor turned around.

“Aarav?”

Aarav immediately sat straight.

“Yes, sir?”

“Something funny?”

“No, sir.”

Meera was trying desperately not to laugh beside him.

The professor continued teaching.

A few seconds later, Aarav received another message.

Meera: *We survived.*

He looked at her.

She was already smiling.

He shook his head.

A few days later, their group decided to watch a movie after college.

Aarav initially refused.

“I'm going home.”

“Why?”

“I'm tired.”

Meera crossed her arms.

“You always say that.”

“Because I'm always tired.”

“Come with us.”

“I don't feel like it.”

She looked at him for a moment.

Then she simply said,

“Okay.”

Aarav expected her to argue.

She didn't.

She just walked away with the others.

For some reason, that made him feel guilty.

Ten minutes later, Aarav appeared at the meeting point.

Meera looked surprised.

“You came?”

Aarav shrugged.

“Maybe.”

She smiled.

“I knew it.”

“No, you didn't.”

“I did.”

“You're lying.”

“Probably.”

He laughed.

The movie wasn't even that good.

But they had fun.

They argued over snacks.

They made fun of each other's reactions.

And when everyone walked out of the theatre, Aarav realized something.

He had forgotten about his problems for almost three hours.

Not because they had disappeared.

Because he had finally stopped thinking about them.

One evening, Meera called him.

“Where are you?”

“Home.”

“Come outside.”

“Why?”

“Just come.”

“Meera, it's almost eight.”

“Exactly.”

“What exactly does that mean?”

“Come outside.”

Aarav sighed.

“You're impossible.”

“I know. Ten minutes.”

He went downstairs.

Meera was standing near the gate with two cups of ice cream.

Aarav stared at her.

“What is this?”

“Emergency ice cream.”

“Emergency?”

“You looked sad today.”

Aarav smiled.

“You came all the way here because I looked sad?”

“Don't make it emotional.”

“I'm not.”

“You are.”

He took the cup from her.

They sat on a nearby bench.

For a while, neither spoke.

Then Meera said,

“You laughed today.”

Aarav looked at her.

“So?”

“You hadn't laughed like that in a long time.”

He looked down at his ice cream.

“I guess.”

“You're getting better.”

Aarav smiled.

“Maybe because you're irritating me every day.”

“Exactly.”

She smiled.

“It's working.”

He laughed again.

But there were still nights when Kiara came back into his thoughts.

One night, Aarav opened an old photograph.

He and Kiara were standing outside their school.

Both were laughing.

He stared at it for a long time.

Then he closed it.

He didn't delete it.

He couldn't.

Some memories didn't need to be erased.

They just needed a place to stay.

The next morning, he met Meera outside college.

She looked at him.

“Everything okay?”

“Yeah.”

“You sure?”

“Yeah.”

She smiled.

“Good.”

They walked inside together.

Aarav didn't tell her about the photograph.

He didn't have to.

She didn't need to know every thought in his head.

She just needed to know that he was still moving forward.

And he was.

Slowly.

As the weeks passed, people around them began noticing how comfortable they had become.

They sat together during lunch.

Walked together after class.

Studied together.

Argued like they had known each other for years.

One of their friends finally said,

“You two are always together.”

Meera immediately replied,

“So?”

The friend smiled.

“Nothing.”

Aarav looked at Meera.

She looked at him.

Neither said anything.

But both smiled.

One evening, they were walking back from college when Meera suddenly stopped.

“What?”

She pointed toward a small street-side stall.

“Golgappa.”

Aarav shook his head.

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because last time you ate too many.”

“That was one time.”

“You couldn't walk properly.”

“I was fine.”

“You were crying.”

“I wasn't crying.”

“You absolutely were.”

She stared at him.

“You remember?”

Aarav smiled.

“Unfortunately.”

She laughed.

“Come on.”

They stood there eating golgappa and arguing about who could handle more spice.

By the end, both were laughing.

Aarav looked at her and thought about something he hadn't thought about in months.

I'm happy.

Not completely.

Not perfectly.

But genuinely.

And it surprised him.

Because he had spent so long believing that happiness meant getting Kiara back.

Maybe it didn't.

Maybe happiness could exist alongside missing someone.

Maybe moving forward didn't mean leaving the past behind.

Maybe it simply meant making room for something new.

He looked at Meera.

She was laughing at something completely stupid.

And he smiled.

Somehow, she had made him laugh again.

Without asking him to forget.

Without trying to replace anyone.

Without even realizing how much she was helping him.

And perhaps that was the most beautiful part.

She wasn't saving him.

She was simply reminding him that life still had good moments.

And for Aarav, that was enough.

CHAPTER 15

Things He Never Said

By now, everyone had noticed.

Aarav was different.

Not completely different.

He still had quiet days.

He still disappeared into his thoughts sometimes.

And there were still moments when Kiara crossed his mind without warning.

But he laughed more.

He joined plans again.

He stayed after class.

He had started becoming the Aarav everyone remembered.

And Meera was almost always somewhere nearby.

Neither of them talked about it.

They didn't need to.

Their friendship had become natural.

Almost effortless.

One afternoon, they were sitting on the college terrace during their break.

Mumbai stretched out in front of them.

Buildings.

Traffic.

People moving between roads.

Meera was eating chips while Aarav was looking at the city.

“Do you ever think about the future?” she asked.

“Sometimes.”

“What do you want?”

“A good career.”

“Obviously.”

“A peaceful life.”

“Obviously.”

“And…”

He stopped.

“And?”

Aarav smiled.

“Nothing.”

Meera looked at him.

“You always do that.”

“Do what?”

“Start saying something and then stop.”

“Maybe I change my mind.”

“No. You get scared to say it.”

Aarav laughed.

“You think you know me very well.”

“I do.”

“That's dangerous.”

“Why?”

“Because then you'll know when I'm lying.”

She smiled.

“I already know.”

Aarav looked at her.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Meera looked away.

“Okay, your turn. Ask me something.”

“What do you want?”

She thought about it.

“I want to travel.”

“Where?”

“Everywhere.”

“That's expensive.”

“Then I'll become rich.”

Aarav laughed.

“Good plan.”

“I know.”

She looked at him.

“And I want people around me who are honest.”

Aarav's smile faded slightly.

“Why?”

“Because I don't like pretending.”

He nodded.

“Neither do I.”

She looked at him.

“Then don't.”

That evening, they stayed back to finish an assignment.

The college had become quiet.

Most students had already left.

They sat across from each other in an empty classroom.

Meera was writing.

Aarav was watching her.

“What?”

He looked away.

“Nothing.”

“You were staring.”

“I wasn't.”

“You were.”

“Okay.”

“What?”

“I was thinking.”

“About?”

Aarav smiled.

“You.”

Meera stopped writing.

“Me?”

“Yeah.”

“Why?”

“I don't know.”

She waited.

Aarav continued,

“You're different from what I expected.”

“Is that good or bad?”

“Good.”

She smiled.

“Thank you.”

He looked down at his notebook.

There were so many things he could have said.

That she had changed his days.

That he looked forward to seeing her.

That her messages had become the first thing he checked some mornings.

That he sometimes wanted to tell her everything.

But he didn't say any of it.

He wasn't ready.

Maybe he didn't even understand it himself.

A few days later, Meera wasn't in college.

Aarav noticed immediately.

He checked his phone.

No message.

During lunch, he asked one of their friends,

“Where's Meera?”

“Not feeling well.”

Aarav nodded.

“Okay.”

He looked at his phone again.

He typed:

Are you okay?

Then sent it.

A few minutes later, his phone vibrated.

Meera: *Alive.*

Aarav smiled.

Aarav: *Good.*

Meera: *That's all?*

Aarav: *What else should I say?*

Meera: *Maybe ask if I'm okay.*

He smiled.

Aarav: *Are you okay?*

Meera: *Now I am.*

Aarav stared at the message.

Something about those words stayed with him.

The next day, Meera returned.

Aarav was waiting outside the classroom.

“You're here.”

She smiled.

“Obviously.”

“You should have rested another day.”

“I was bored.”

“You were sick.”

“I survived.”

Aarav shook his head.

“You never listen.”

“And you worry too much.”

He paused.

“Maybe.”

Meera smiled.

“Thank you.”

“For what?”

“For checking on me.”

Aarav shrugged.

“Friends do that.”

She looked at him for a second.

“Yeah.”

Then they walked into class together.

That afternoon, their group made plans for the weekend.

“Let's go somewhere,” one of their friends suggested.

“Where?”

“Matheran?”

Everyone agreed.

Aarav looked at Meera.

She was already smiling.

“You wanted to go,” he said.

“So did you.”

“True.”

They started making plans.

Who would come.

Who would bring what.

Who would drive.

Where they would stay.

What places they would visit.

The excitement spread through the group.

For the first time in a long time, Aarav was looking forward to something.

Not because he wanted to escape.

Because he wanted to experience it.

With them.

With Meera.

That night, Aarav lay in bed thinking about the trip.

He opened his phone.

There was a message from Meera.

Meera: *Don't forget your jacket.*

He smiled.

Aarav: *I know.*

Meera: *You forgot it last time.*

Aarav: *How do you remember everything?*

Meera: *Someone has to.*

Aarav stared at the screen.

Then typed something.

I don't know what I would have done without you.

His thumb hovered over send.

He deleted it.

Instead, he wrote:

Aarav: *Goodnight.*

Her reply came quickly.

Meera: *Goodnight, Overthinker.*

Aarav put his phone beside him.

He closed his eyes.

But one thought remained.

There were things he never said.

Not because they weren't true.

Because sometimes the heart understands something long before the mind is ready to admit it.

And Aarav was beginning to wonder if Meera had become more than just someone who made him laugh.

He wasn't ready to call it anything.

Not yet.

But the feeling was there.

Quiet.

Growing.

Waiting.

And Matheran was only a few days away.

CHAPTER 16

The Person Beside Him

The week passed faster than Aarav expected.

Before he knew it, Friday had arrived.

The Matheran trip was finally happening.

Their group had been talking about it for days.

Plans changed every few hours.

Someone forgot something.

Someone brought too much luggage.

Someone wanted to change the playlist.

And somehow, despite all the chaos, everyone was excited.

Aarav reached the meeting point early.

He stood beside his bike, checking the bags again.

“Overthinker.”

He turned.

Meera was standing behind him with a backpack.

“You're early.”

“So are you.”

“I know.”

She smiled.

“You checked everything?”

“Three times.”

“Of course.”

Aarav looked at her bag.

“That's all?”

“Yep.”

“For two days?”

“I'm efficient.”

“You've packed half the house.”

She laughed.

“Don't judge me.”

Their friends slowly arrived.

Within minutes, the quiet morning became noisy.

Everyone was talking.

Someone was taking photographs.

Someone was arguing about music.

Someone was already asking when they would stop for food.

Aarav smiled.

It felt good.

It felt normal.

The journey to Matheran was full of laughter.

Music played.

Everyone sang badly.

They stopped for breakfast.

Someone spilled a drink.

Meera blamed Aarav.

Aarav blamed everyone else.

At one point, Meera was sitting beside him while the others were talking loudly behind them.

She looked out of the window.

“It's beautiful.”

Aarav looked outside.

The city slowly disappeared behind them.

Green hills replaced buildings.

The air felt different.

“You were right,” Meera said.

“About?”

“This was a good idea.”

Aarav smiled.

“You're admitting I was right?”

“Don't get used to it.”

He laughed.

When they finally reached Matheran, everyone became excited.

The hills.

The trees.

The cool air.

The narrow paths.

The views.

It felt like a completely different world.

They checked into the resort and dropped their bags.

Then immediately went outside.

They explored viewpoints, took photographs, joked around, and tried to find the best places for sunset.

At one viewpoint, Aarav stood slightly away from the group.

He looked at the valley below.

Meera walked over.

“You okay?”

“Yeah.”

“You've been quiet.”

“Just looking.”

She stood beside him.

“Beautiful, right?”

“Yeah.”

A few seconds passed.

Then Meera said,

“You look happier here.”

Aarav smiled.

“I am.”

She smiled too.

“Good.”

That evening, everyone gathered around outside the resort.

Someone brought a speaker.

Music played.

People danced.

Someone started telling embarrassing stories.

Aarav laughed harder than he had in months.

Meera sat beside him.

She watched him laughing.

She didn't say anything.

But she smiled.

Later, when everyone went inside, Aarav remained outside.

Meera joined him.

“You're not tired?”

“A little.”

“Then why are you still here?”

“I like the night.”

She sat beside him.

“So do I.”

The two of them looked up at the sky.

“Do you ever think,” Meera said, “that some people come into your life at exactly the right time?”

Aarav looked at her.

“Maybe.”

“I think they do.”

He smiled.

“Why are you saying this?”

“No reason.”

She looked away.

Aarav wanted to ask more.

But he didn't.

Instead, he said,

“I'm glad you came.”

Meera looked at him.

“I'm glad you did too.”

There was something different in that moment.

Not dramatic.

Not obvious.

Just a quiet feeling neither of them named.

The next morning, the group went exploring again.

They walked along a forest trail.

Meera slipped slightly on the uneven path.

Aarav immediately reached out his hand.

“Careful.”

She held it for a second.

“Thanks.”

Then she let go.

It was a tiny moment.

But both of them noticed it.

Neither mentioned it.

By afternoon, everyone was exhausted.

They returned to the resort.

Some went to their rooms.

Some stayed outside.

Aarav sat on the balcony.

Meera came and sat beside him.

“You're quiet again.”

“Just thinking.”

“About Kiara?”

Aarav looked at her.

For a moment, he didn't answer.

“Sometimes.”

Meera nodded.

“You don't have to stop.”

“I know.”

Aarav looked toward the hills.

“But things are different now.”

Meera looked at him.

“How?”

He thought carefully.

“I don't feel like I'm waiting anymore.”

She smiled softly.

“That's good.”

“Yeah.”

He looked at her.

“Because I have people around me now.”

Meera smiled.

“People?”

“Friends.”

She raised an eyebrow.

“Just friends?”

Aarav laughed.

“What else?”

She smiled.

“Nothing.”

That evening, something changed.

The group secretly started preparing something.

Aarav didn't know what.

Every time he entered a room, conversations stopped.

Every time he asked what was happening, everyone said,

“Nothing.”

He became suspicious.

“Something is definitely happening.”

Meera smiled innocently.

“Nothing is happening.”

“You're lying.”

“Maybe.”

“Meera.”

“Aarav.”

He laughed.

“Fine.”

That night, everyone went to their rooms earlier than usual.

Aarav thought the day was over.

He changed his clothes and was about to sleep when one of his friends knocked on the door.

“Come downstairs.”

“Why?”

“Just come.”

“Now?”

“Yes.”

Aarav sighed.

“Okay.”

He walked downstairs.

The entire resort area was dark.

The lights were off.

He looked around.

“What's going on?”

No answer.

“Aarav!”

Someone called his name.

He turned.

Then suddenly—

the lights came on.

Music started playing.

Everyone was standing there.

And in the middle of them was Meera.

She was holding a small bouquet.

Aarav froze.

He didn't understand.

His friends began cheering.

Meera took a step forward.

She looked nervous.

But she smiled.

“Aarav…”

He stared at her.

She took a breath.

“I've wanted to say something for a long time.”

The noise around them faded.

Aarav couldn't hear anything except her voice.

Meera looked directly at him.

“I know you've been through a lot.”

Aarav remained silent.

“And I know there are parts of your past you'll always care about.”

Her voice became softer.

“But somewhere along the way…”

She smiled.

“…I started caring about you too.”

Aarav's heart began beating faster.

The entire group stood quietly.

Meera took another breath.

“I don't know what happens after college.”

“I don't know what tomorrow looks like.”

“But I know that when I'm with you…”

She smiled.

“…I feel like I'm exactly where I want to be.”

Aarav couldn't move.

Meera held out the bouquet.

“So, Aarav…”

She looked into his eyes.

“Would you give me a chance?”

Silence.

Everyone waited.

Aarav looked at her.

Then at the people around them.

Then back at Meera.

His mind was completely blank.

He didn't know what to say.

He didn't know what the right answer was.

And before anyone could understand what he was thinking—

Aarav quietly turned around.

And walked away.

CHAPTER 17

The Longest Ride Back

Aarav walked upstairs without saying a word.

Behind him, the music had stopped.

Nobody followed.

For a few seconds, everyone simply stood there, confused.

Meera remained where she was.

The bouquet was still in her hands.

Her smile was gone.

She looked down.

She had imagined many possible answers.

A yes.

A no.

Maybe even a joke because Aarav didn't know how to handle emotional situations.

But she hadn't imagined silence.

She hadn't imagined him walking away.

One of their friends quietly approached her.

“Meera…”

She shook her head.

“It's okay.”

But her voice didn't sound okay.

She placed the bouquet on the table.

“I think I just need some time.”

Then she walked toward her room.

Aarav closed the door behind him.

He leaned against it.

His heart was racing.

He couldn't understand why he had walked away.

Meera hadn't done anything wrong.

She had been honest.

She had stood in front of everyone and told him how she felt.

And he had left.

He sat on the edge of the bed.

His mind went back to the day he and Kiara had fought.

The anger.

The words.

The silence afterward.

The months of wondering what had really happened.

He remembered telling Kiara,

“I can live without you.”

He remembered telling her to leave him alone.

And then he remembered how much he had regretted those words.

He didn't want to hurt someone like that again.

Especially not Meera.

But there was another truth he couldn't ignore.

He cared about Meera.

A lot.

Maybe more than he had allowed himself to admit.

He just didn't know if he was ready.

A few minutes later, Aarav picked up his keys.

He walked downstairs.

Nobody stopped him.

Outside, the night air was cold.

He got on his bike.

For a moment, he simply sat there.

Then he started the engine.

And rode.

He didn't know where he was going.

He only knew he needed to think.

The road stretched ahead.

The lights passed one after another.

And with every kilometre, his thoughts became clearer.

He thought about the first time Meera had seen him after the fight.

She hadn't asked him to forget Kiara.

She hadn't judged him.

She had simply sat beside him.

He thought about the beach.

The new number in his phone.

The memes.

The ice cream.

The stupid arguments.

The movie.

The golgappa.

The library.

The way she always knew when he was overthinking.

The way she never made his past feel like a problem.

She had never tried to take Kiara's place.

She had simply become Meera.

And somewhere along the way, Aarav had started looking forward to seeing her.

He stopped his bike near a quiet viewpoint.

He took off his helmet and sat there.

The city lights stretched far into the distance.

He looked at his phone.

One notification.

Meera.

He didn't open it.

He already knew what it would probably say.

He felt guilty.

She had been brave enough to tell him the truth.

And he had been too afraid to tell her his.

Aarav looked down.

“I'm sorry,” he whispered.

Then he realized something.

Saying sorry from a distance wasn't enough.

He had spent months regretting what he had said to Kiara.

He wasn't going to repeat the same mistake.

He couldn't promise Meera a perfect future.

He couldn't promise that the past would suddenly disappear.

But he could be honest.

And maybe honesty was all she deserved.

Aarav started the bike again.

This time, he knew exactly where he was going.

Back to the resort.

Back to Meera.

The ride felt longer than it should have.

Every traffic light felt like it was taking forever.

Every turn made him think again.

What if she didn't want to see him?

What if she was angry?

What if she regretted telling him?

What if he had already ruined everything?

He didn't know.

But for once, he wasn't running away from the answer.

He was going toward it.

When Aarav finally returned, the resort was quiet.

Most of the lights were off.

He walked inside.

One of their friends saw him.

“You came back.”

Aarav nodded.

“Where's Meera?”

The friend looked at him for a moment.

“Outside.”

Aarav walked toward the balcony.

Meera was standing alone, looking at the hills.

She heard his footsteps.

She turned.

Their eyes met.

Neither spoke.

Aarav stopped a few feet away.

“Meera…”

She looked away.

“I don't want to make you uncomfortable.”

“You already did.”

He lowered his eyes.

“I know.”

A pause.

“I'm sorry.”

She didn't answer.

“I shouldn't have walked away.”

“No,” she said quietly. “You shouldn't have.”

Aarav nodded.

“I was scared.”

Meera looked at him.

“Of me?”

“No.”

“Then what?”

Aarav took a breath.

“Of making the same mistake again.”

She stayed silent.

“I've already lost someone because I let my anger and fear speak for me.”

His voice became quieter.

“I didn't want to hurt you too.”

Meera looked at him.

“Then why did you leave?”

“Because I didn't know what to say.”

She waited.

Aarav finally looked directly at her.

“But I know what I don't want.”

“What?”

“I don't want to lose you.”

Meera's expression softened.

Aarav continued.

“I don't know what tomorrow will feel like.”

“I don't know if I'll ever completely stop missing what I lost.”

“But I know what I feel when I'm with you.”

Meera didn't move.

“You make me happy.”

A small smile appeared on her face.

“And I don't want to run away from that.”

Aarav stepped closer.

“So…”

He took a breath.

“If you're still willing…”

Meera looked at him.

“Willing to what?”

Aarav smiled nervously.

“To give me a chance.”

For a moment, she said nothing.

Then she smiled.

“You took a very long time.”

Aarav laughed softly.

“I know.”

“You made me cry.”

“I know.”

“You owe me.”

“I definitely know that.”

She laughed through the tears in her eyes.

Aarav smiled.

“So… is that a yes?”

Meera looked at him.

“Yes.”

The word was quiet.

But it changed everything.

Aarav smiled.

Meera smiled too.

Neither of them needed a grand moment anymore.

They simply stood there under the quiet night sky.

And for the first time, Aarav wasn't thinking about what he had lost.

He was thinking about what was standing in front of him.

Meera.

The person who had stayed.

The person who had never asked him to forget yesterday.

The person who had given him a reason to look forward to today.

And somewhere in the middle of that quiet night in Matheran, Aarav finally understood something:

Sometimes moving forward doesn't mean forgetting the person behind you.

Sometimes it means choosing not to lose the person beside you.

CHAPTER 18

Our Final Year

The morning after Matheran felt different.

Nothing around them had changed.

The same resort.

The same group.

The same hills.

The same breakfast table where everyone was already arguing about who had slept the least.

But Aarav and Meera were different.

They had crossed a line neither of them could uncross.

They were together now.

Not because everything in Aarav's past had disappeared.

Not because Meera had replaced anyone.

But because they had chosen each other.

And somehow, that felt enough.

On the journey back to Mumbai, Meera sat beside Aarav.

For most of the ride, neither said much.

Then she quietly asked,

“So…”

Aarav looked at her.

“So?”

“We're actually together?”

He smiled.

“I think so.”

“You *think* so?”

“I'm confirming.”

She laughed.

“You're impossible.”

“You knew that before.”

She looked out the window.

Then smiled.

“I did.”

Aarav looked at her for a moment.

He still couldn't believe it.

The girl who had once been just another person from college was now sitting beside him, holding his hand beneath the edge of the seat where nobody could see.

It was simple.

And somehow, it meant everything.

The months that followed became their favorite part of college.

They studied together.

Went for coffee after lectures.

Shared notes.

Argued about silly things.

Made up before the arguments even had time to become serious.

Meera would sometimes steal Aarav's phone.

Aarav would hide her notebook.

She would call him annoying.

He would call her dramatic.

And both would laugh.

Their friends noticed immediately.

“You two have become unbearable,” one of them said one afternoon.

Meera smiled.

“You're just jealous.”

Aarav laughed.

“She's right.”

Their friend shook his head.

“Whatever.”

But their relationship wasn't perfect.

Sometimes Aarav became quiet.

Sometimes Meera wondered if he was thinking about Kiara.

One evening, they were sitting at Marine Drive.

Meera looked at him.

“You're thinking about her.”

Aarav didn't deny it.

“Sometimes.”

Meera nodded.

“Okay.”

He looked at her.

“Are you angry?”

“No.”

“You're sure?”

“Yes.”

She looked toward the sea.

“She was part of your life for years.”

Aarav remained quiet.

“I can't expect you to erase that.”

He looked at her.

“You really don't mind?”

“Of course I mind sometimes.”

He was surprised.

Meera smiled.

“I'm human.”

Aarav laughed softly.

“But I trust you.”

That sentence meant more to him than she knew.

He took her hand.

“I don't want you to ever feel like you're second.”

Meera smiled.

“Then don't make me feel that way.”

“I won't.”

And he meant it.

Their final year arrived before either of them was ready.

Suddenly, graduation wasn't some distant idea.

It was approaching.

Assignments became more serious.

Exams became important.

Everyone started talking about jobs, interviews and the future.

The same college corridors that once felt endless suddenly seemed too short.

One afternoon, Aarav and Meera sat outside their classroom after their final lecture.

“Can you believe it?” Meera asked.

“What?”

“We're almost done.”

Aarav looked around.

“Feels like yesterday.”

“When I first saw you, I thought you were arrogant.”

“I was quiet.”

“You looked arrogant.”

“And you?”

“I was perfect.”

Aarav laughed.

“Obviously.”

She smiled.

Then her expression became softer.

“I'm going to miss this.”

“Me too.”

“The canteen.”

“Definitely.”

“The terrace.”

“Maybe.”

“The professors?”

“No.”

She laughed.

“The people?”

Aarav looked at her.

“Yes.”

She smiled.

“Me too.”

Their final college festival arrived.

Everyone dressed up.

Photos were taken everywhere.

People signed each other's shirts and notebooks.

Friends promised to stay in touch forever.

Aarav and Meera took photographs together.

One of their friends looked at them and said,

“Remember this moment.”

Aarav smiled.

“I will.”

Meera looked at him.

“So will I.”

That evening, they stood on the college terrace one last time.

The sun was setting.

The same place where they had once talked about the future.

Meera leaned against the railing.

“What do you think happens after this?”

Aarav smiled.

“We find out.”

“That sounds very confident.”

“I'm pretending.”

She laughed.

He looked at her.

“No matter where we go, I don't want this to become just a college memory.”

“It won't.”

“You promise?”

She held out her little finger.

“Promise.”

Aarav hooked his finger with hers.

“Promise.”

Their final exams came.

They studied late.

Complained about difficult questions.

Celebrated after every exam.

And slowly, one by one, the last days disappeared.

Then came graduation.

Aarav stood in his graduation clothes, looking around the hall.

Three years.

Three years of memories.

Three years of friendships.

Three years of mistakes.

Three years of becoming someone different.

He looked at Meera.

She was smiling at him.

He smiled back.

After the ceremony, they walked outside together.

Their friends were taking photographs.

Everyone was laughing.

Someone shouted,

“Future CEO couple!”

Meera laughed.

Aarav shook his head.

“Idiots.”

Then he looked at her.

“Ready?”

“For what?”

“For whatever comes next.”

She smiled.

“With you?”

“Yes.”

“Then yes.”

Aarav smiled.

They walked away from the college together.

Neither of them knew exactly what the future would bring.

But they knew they had made it this far.

And for the first time, Aarav wasn't afraid of what came next.

Because he wasn't walking into it alone.

He had Meera beside him.

And sometimes, that was all the certainty a person needed.

CHAPTER 19

After the Last Day

The day after graduation felt strangely quiet.

There were no lectures.

No attendance.

No assignments waiting to be submitted.

No professor asking why they were late.

No reason to hurry toward the college gate.

For three years, St. Aurelia College had been a part of Aarav's everyday life.

And suddenly, it wasn't.

He woke up later than usual and reached for his phone.

There was already a message from Meera.

Meera: *Good morning, graduate.*

Aarav smiled.

Aarav: *Good morning.*

A second message arrived.

Meera: *So what are we doing today?*

He thought for a moment.

Aarav: *Nothing.*

Meera: *Wrong answer.*

Aarav: *Why?*

Meera: *Because we're free.*

Aarav smiled.

She was right.

They were free.

But freedom suddenly felt strange.

They met later that afternoon at their usual café.

For the first time, they weren't discussing lectures or assignments.

They talked about jobs.

Future plans.

Travel.

Families.

Where they wanted to live.

What kind of life they wanted.

Meera stirred her coffee.

“Do you think we'll stay in Mumbai?”

Aarav looked outside.

“I think so.”

“Even after everything?”

He smiled.

“It's home.”

She nodded.

“I like it too.”

A small silence followed.

Then Meera asked,

“Are you scared?”

“About what?”

“Everything.”

Aarav thought.

“A little.”

“Me too.”

He reached across the table and held her hand.

“We'll figure it out.”

She smiled.

“You always say that.”

“Because it's true.”

The next few weeks passed quickly.

Aarav started looking for work.

Meera began planning her own future.

Their group met less often.

Everyone became busy.

Some moved to different cities.

Some started working.

Some continued studying.

The group chat that had once been filled with messages every hour slowly became quieter.

But Aarav and Meera stayed close.

They called at night.

Met whenever they could.

Went for walks.

Had long conversations about absolutely nothing.

Their relationship had changed too.

College had given them endless time together.

Now they had to make time.

And somehow, they did.

One evening, Aarav and Meera went back to St. Aurelia College.

The campus was almost empty.

They stood outside their old classroom.

Meera smiled.

“Remember this room?”

“Unfortunately.”

“You failed to submit an assignment here.”

“You reminded me for three days.”

“Because you would've forgotten.”

“I didn't forget.”

“You absolutely forgot.”

Aarav laughed.

They walked through the corridor.

Everything looked smaller now.

The classroom.

The canteen.

The staircase.

Even the terrace.

Meera stopped near the railing.

“This place changed everything.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Yeah.”

“If we hadn't come here…”

“I wouldn't have met you.”

She smiled.

“And you wouldn't have met Kiara again.”

Aarav's smile faded slightly.

He looked toward the city.

“I still wonder about her.”

Meera nodded.

“I know.”

“I hope she's okay.”

“She probably is.”

“I wish I knew what happened.”

Meera didn't answer.

She simply stood beside him.

That night, Aarav returned home and found himself thinking about the past again.

He opened an old drawer.

Inside was a photograph from school.

Aarav and Kiara.

Both younger.

Both smiling.

He sat on the edge of his bed.

He hadn't looked at the photograph in months.

He wasn't angry anymore.

He wasn't even bitter.

He simply missed the friendship.

He wondered where she was.

What she was doing.

Whether she ever thought about him.

Then his phone rang.

It was Meera.

“Hello?”

“Are you home?”

“Yeah.”

“You sound quiet.”

“Just thinking.”

“About her?”

Aarav smiled faintly.

“Yeah.”

There was a pause.

Then Meera said,

“Do you want to talk?”

Aarav looked at the photograph.

“Maybe.”

He told her about school.

About Class 9.

About how he and Kiara became friends.

About their first trip.

Their stupid arguments.

Their plans.

The things he had never told anyone.

Meera listened.

She didn't interrupt.

When he finished, she said,

“I understand now.”

“Understand what?”

“Why you couldn't just forget her.”

Aarav looked down.

“I never wanted to forget her.”

“I know.”

“I just wanted to stop hurting.”

“And did you?”

He thought about it.

“Most days.”

Meera smiled through the phone.

“That's enough.”

A few weeks later, life had settled into a new rhythm.

Aarav was slowly building his career.

Meera was doing the same.

They were happy.

Not the loud kind of happy they had experienced in college.

A quieter happiness.

The kind that existed in phone calls, evening walks and small plans for the weekend.

Aarav thought the hardest chapter of his life was finally behind him.

He was wrong.

Because one ordinary evening, while walking home, his phone rang.

The number wasn't saved.

He almost ignored it.

Then he answered.

“Hello?”

There was silence on the other end.

“Hello?”

A familiar voice finally spoke.

“Aarav?”

He stopped walking.

His heart seemed to pause.

He knew that voice.

He had heard it thousands of times.

“Kiara?”

Silence.

Then she said quietly,

“Can we meet?”

Aarav couldn't answer.

After all these years, after all those unanswered questions—

the person he had spent months trying to forget was finally calling him.

And suddenly, yesterday wasn't as far away as he had thought.

CHAPTER 20

The Person Who Came Back

Aarav didn't sleep much that night.

Kiara's voice kept replaying in his mind.

Can we meet?

Three words.

Three years of memories behind them.

He had imagined this moment countless times.

Sometimes he imagined shouting at her.

Sometimes he imagined asking why she left.

Sometimes he imagined simply walking away.

But now that the moment had actually arrived, he didn't know what he wanted.

The next morning, he told Meera.

“She called.”

Meera looked at him.

“Kiara?”

He nodded.

“What did she say?”

“She wants to meet.”

Meera was quiet for a moment.

“Then meet her.”

Aarav looked surprised.

“You're okay with that?”

Meera smiled.

“I trust you.”

“But what if—”

“Don't think about what if.”

She reached for his hand.

“Go get the answers you've been waiting for.”

Aarav nodded.

“Thank you.”

They decided to meet at a small café near the place where they had gone to school.

Aarav arrived early.

He sat near the window.

His hands were cold.

He kept looking toward the entrance.

Then the door opened.

Kiara walked in.

For a moment, everything stopped.

She looked familiar.

And different.

Older.

More mature.

But still Kiara.

The same person who had once known almost everything about him.

Their eyes met.

She smiled faintly.

“Hi.”

Aarav stood.

“Hi.”

Neither knew what to say next.

Finally, they sat down.

A few seconds passed.

Kiara looked at him.

“You look different.”

“So do you.”

She smiled.

“Fair.”

Silence returned.

Then Aarav finally asked the question he had been carrying for years.

“Why did you leave?”

Kiara looked down.

“I didn't.”

Aarav stared at her.

“What?”

“I never chose to leave you.”

He couldn't speak.

Kiara took a breath.

“That day, when you called me again and again… my phone wasn't working.”

Aarav frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“I had been having problems with it. Then…”

She paused.

“There was an accident.”

Aarav's expression changed.

“An accident?”

Kiara nodded.

“I was hurt.”

He remained silent.

“My phone was damaged. I couldn't contact anyone properly. My family took me away from Mumbai while I recovered.”

Aarav looked down.

“Why didn't anyone tell me?”

“I thought someone would.”

She shook her head.

“Then things became complicated. I wasn't in a position to contact you.”

Aarav swallowed.

“All those months…”

“I know.”

“I thought you just stopped caring.”

Kiara looked at him.

“I thought you hated me.”

Aarav's eyes became heavy.

“I didn't.”

“I know that now.”

They sat quietly.

Then Kiara smiled sadly.

“You know what hurt the most?”

“What?”

“The last thing you said.”

Aarav looked down.

“I know.”

“You told me you could live without me.”

“I was angry.”

“I know.”

“And I didn't mean it.”

“I know that too.”

Aarav looked at her.

“I'm sorry.”

Kiara smiled.

“I waited a long time to hear that.”

“I should have said it sooner.”

“Maybe.”

She looked out the window.

“But we can't change that day.”

Aarav nodded.

“No.”

They sat in silence for a while.

Then Kiara asked,

“Are you happy?”

Aarav knew exactly what she meant.

He smiled.

“Yes.”

“With Meera?”

“Yes.”

Kiara smiled.

“Good.”

Aarav looked at her.

“You're not angry?”

“Why would I be?”

“Because things changed.”

“They were always going to change.”

Aarav didn't understand.

Kiara continued,

“We were best friends for years. I think that's why I believed we had to stay exactly the same forever.”

She smiled.

“But people grow.”

Aarav nodded slowly.

“I still miss our friendship.”

“So do I.”

“Can we…”

He stopped.

Kiara looked at him.

“Can we be friends again?”

She smiled.

“Maybe.”

Aarav laughed softly.

“Maybe?”

“You'll have to earn it.”

He smiled.

“Fair.”

For the first time in years, they laughed together.

Not like before.

Something had changed.

But it wasn't painful anymore.

When Aarav left the café, he stood outside for a moment.

He felt lighter.

Not because the past had disappeared.

Because he finally understood it.

He took out his phone and called Meera.

“Hello?”

“I met her.”

“And?”

Aarav smiled.

“We talked.”

“Are you okay?”

“Yeah.”

“Really?”

“Really.”

Meera smiled through the phone.

“Good.”

Aarav looked toward the road.

“She didn't leave me.”

Meera was quiet.

“I know.”

“I spent years being angry at someone who never abandoned me.”

“Sometimes we create answers when we don't have the truth.”

Aarav smiled.

“You always know what to say.”

“Obviously.”

He laughed.

“Meera?”

“Hmm?”

“Thank you.”

“For what?”

“For staying.”

There was a short silence.

Then she said,

“I told you. I'm not going anywhere.”

Aarav smiled.

That evening, Aarav went back to the beach.

The same beach where Meera had found him months ago.

The same place where he had once sat alone, thinking his life would never feel normal again.

He stood near the water.

Then he heard footsteps behind him.

Meera.

She walked over.

“You came here again.”

“Yeah.”

“Why?”

Aarav looked at the sea.

“Because I think this is where everything changed.”

Meera smiled.

“And?”

“And I wanted to come back.”

They stood beside each other.

Aarav looked at her.

“I finally stopped waiting for an answer.”

Meera smiled.

“And what did you find?”

Aarav took her hand.

“The truth.”

She squeezed his hand.

“Good.”

He smiled.

“And you.”

Meera laughed.

“You're getting very emotional.”

“Maybe.”

She rested her head lightly against his shoulder.

The waves moved quietly in front of them.

For the first time, Aarav wasn't caught between yesterday and tomorrow.

He was simply there.

With Meera.

And for now, that was enough.

CHAPTER 21

I Don't Want to Lose You

The days after Aarav met Kiara felt different.

Not because anything had changed between Aarav and Meera.

If anything, things felt calmer.

Aarav no longer carried the same questions everywhere he went.

He didn't wake up wondering where Kiara was.

He didn't replay their last argument every night.

He finally knew the truth.

And somehow, knowing the truth made it easier to let the past rest.

But there was one thing Aarav had started thinking about more than ever.

Meera.

Not because he was afraid she would leave.

Because he had finally understood how easily people could disappear from your life.

Sometimes because of an argument.

Sometimes because of circumstances you couldn't control.

And sometimes simply because life changed.

One evening, Aarav and Meera were walking along Marine Drive.

The sea was calm.

The city lights reflected on the water.

Meera was telling him about something that had happened at work when Aarav suddenly stopped.

She turned around.

“What?”

He looked at her.

“Nothing.”

“You stopped walking.”

“I know.”

“Why?”

Aarav smiled.

“I was thinking.”

“Again?”

“Yeah.”

She laughed.

“You really need to stop doing that.”

He smiled.

“I don't think I can.”

She started walking again.

Aarav followed.

After a few seconds, he said,

“Meera.”

“Hmm?”

“I don't want to lose you.”

She stopped.

The smile on her face slowly disappeared.

Not because she was sad.

Because she understood that he wasn't saying it casually.

Aarav continued.

“I've lost people before.”

“Some because of my own mistakes.”

“Some because I didn't know the truth.”

“And some because life just changed.”

Meera listened quietly.

“I don't want to make the same mistake with you.”

She looked at him.

“You won't.”

“How do you know?”

“Because you're not the same person you were then.”

Aarav smiled faintly.

“Maybe.”

“No,” she said. “Definitely.”

He looked at the sea.

“I used to think that loving someone meant never letting them leave.”

Meera waited.

“Now I think it's different.”

“How?”

“It means trusting them enough to stay, even when life becomes difficult.”

She smiled.

“That's a better definition.”

Aarav looked at her.

“You taught me that.”

“I didn't teach you anything.”

“You did.”

“How?”

“You stayed.”

Meera smiled.

“Then I'll keep staying.”

A few weeks later, Kiara and Meera finally met properly.

There was no dramatic confrontation.

No jealousy.

No competition.

Just three people who had been connected by the same story in completely different ways.

They met at a café.

Aarav sat between them, looking slightly nervous.

Meera noticed.

“Why do you look so scared?”

“I'm not scared.”

Kiara laughed.

“He's definitely scared.”

Aarav looked at both of them.

“Can we please have one normal conversation?”

Meera smiled.

“Of course.”

Kiara looked at Meera.

“I've heard a lot about you.”

Meera smiled.

“Hopefully good things.”

“Mostly.”

Aarav interrupted.

“Mostly?”

Kiara laughed.

“You still haven't changed.”

“And you still make fun of me.”

“Some things don't change.”

The three of them laughed.

For the first time, there was no awkwardness.

No old competition.

No unfinished anger.

Just acceptance.

At one point, Kiara looked at Meera.

“Take care of him.”

Aarav immediately looked embarrassed.

“Kiara…”

Meera smiled.

“I will.”

Kiara nodded.

“I know.”

Aarav looked between them.

He had once been terrified that these two parts of his life could never exist together.

But they could.

Not in the same way.

Not as one perfect story.

But peacefully.

And that was enough.

Later that evening, Aarav walked Meera home.

“You were nervous,” she said.

“I was not.”

“You were.”

“Okay. Maybe a little.”

She smiled.

“You didn't need to be.”

“I know that now.”

They reached her gate.

Neither immediately said goodbye.

Meera looked at him.

“What?”

Aarav smiled.

“Nothing.”

“You've said that about twenty times today.”

“Maybe I just like looking at you.”

She laughed.

“That's new.”

“It's not.”

She smiled.

Aarav took her hand.

“Thank you.”

“For?”

“For being patient with me.”

Meera squeezed his hand.

“You were worth waiting for.”

Aarav smiled.

“I love you.”

The words came naturally.

No hesitation.

No fear.

Meera smiled.

“I love you too.”

For a moment, neither said anything.

Then Meera laughed.

“What?”

“You took forever.”

Aarav laughed.

“I know.”

That night, Aarav returned home.

He opened his phone.

There were old photographs.

Old conversations.

Old memories.

He looked through them one last time.

Then he closed the gallery.

Not because he wanted to erase anything.

Because he no longer needed to live inside those memories.

He placed the phone beside him.

Outside, Mumbai was still awake.

Cars moved through the streets.

Lights filled the buildings.

The city continued as it always had.

And Aarav finally understood something.

He couldn't control who stayed.

He couldn't control who left.

He couldn't change yesterday.

But he could choose what he did with today.

And today, he had Meera.

The person who had found him when he was alone.

The person who had stayed when he was difficult to understand.

The person who had never demanded that he forget his past.

The person who had simply asked him to be honest.

Aarav smiled.

For once, tomorrow didn't scare him.

Because whatever happened next, he knew one thing.

He wasn't going to run away anymore.

CHAPTER 22

Today

A few months passed.

Life had settled into something Aarav had once thought he would never have.

A job.

A routine.

A small circle of people he trusted.

And Meera.

They weren't living a perfect life.

Some days were exhausting.

Some days they barely had time to talk.

Sometimes they argued over the smallest things.

But they always came back to each other.

That mattered.

One Friday evening, Meera called him.

“Are you busy?”

“Not anymore.”

“Good.”

“Why?”

“Come with me.”

“Where?”

“I'm not telling you.”

Aarav smiled.

“That's suspicious.”

“Just come.”

“Give me ten minutes.”

“Twenty.”

“Why twenty?”

“Because I know you. You'll take fifteen.”

Aarav laughed.

“You know me too well.”

“I know.”

Twenty minutes later, Aarav reached the place.

He stopped when he realized where they were.

The beach.

The same beach.

The place where Meera had first found him sitting alone.

The place where they had exchanged numbers.

The place where Aarav had once believed his life had become empty.

Meera was standing near the water.

She turned when she heard him.

“You remember?”

Aarav smiled.

“How could I forget?”

She walked toward him.

“I thought we should come back.”

“Why?”

“Because so much happened here.”

Aarav looked toward the sea.

“Yeah.”

They walked along the shore.

For a while, neither spoke.

Then Meera said,

“Do you ever think about how different everything was that day?”

Aarav smiled.

“I was sitting alone.”

“You looked miserable.”

“I was miserable.”

“I thought you were going to ignore me.”

“I almost did.”

She looked at him.

“Really?”

“I didn't want to talk to anyone.”

“But you talked to me.”

“I don't know why.”

Meera smiled.

“Maybe you needed someone.”

“Maybe.”

They continued walking.

The sun slowly began to set.

Aarav stopped.

Meera looked at him.

“What?”

He smiled.

“I was just thinking.”

“About what?”

“How much changed.”

She waited.

“I thought I had lost everything when Kiara disappeared.”

Meera remained quiet.

“I thought I'd never feel normal again.”

He looked at her.

“Then you came along.”

Meera smiled.

“I didn't do anything special.”

“You did.”

“How?”

“You stayed.”

She looked down, smiling.

Aarav continued.

“You never asked me to forget her.”

“You never made me choose between my past and my present.”

“You just gave me a reason to keep moving.”

Meera looked at him.

“And now?”

Aarav smiled.

“Now I don't feel like I'm trying to move anymore.”

“Then what are you doing?”

He looked toward the setting sun.

“Living.”

Meera smiled.

“That's a good answer.”

They sat on the sand.

The waves came quietly toward them and disappeared again.

Aarav looked at the horizon.

“I used to think the past was something I had to escape.”

“And now?”

“Now I think it's just a part of me.”

Meera nodded.

“You don't have to forget where you came from.”

“I know.”

He looked at her.

“I just don't want to spend my life looking behind me.”

Meera smiled.

“Then don't.”

Aarav took her hand.

“I won't.”

His phone vibrated.

A message from Kiara.

Kiara: *Hope you're doing well.*

Aarav smiled.

He replied.

I am. Hope you are too.

A simple conversation.

No sadness.

No unfinished questions.

No need to go back.

He put his phone away.

Meera looked at him.

“Everything okay?”

“Yeah.”

“What did she say?”

“Just wished me well.”

Meera smiled.

“Good.”

Aarav looked at her.

“You know something?”

“What?”

“I spent so much time trying to forget the person I couldn't forget…”

He paused.

“…that I almost missed the person who was standing beside me.”

Meera smiled.

“That sounds like something from a movie.”

“Maybe.”

“Very dramatic.”

“I'm allowed.”

She laughed.

Aarav smiled.

Then the two of them looked toward the sea.

The sun was almost gone.

The sky had turned orange.

The city lights were beginning to appear behind them.

Meera leaned slightly closer.

“Are you okay?”

Aarav looked at her.

This time, there was no hesitation.

“Yes.”

She smiled.

“Really?”

He nodded.

“I think I finally stopped waiting for yesterday.”

Meera looked at him.

“And started?”

Aarav smiled.

“Today.”

She held his hand tighter.

And they stayed there as the evening slowly became night.

Not waiting for the past.

Not afraid of the future.

Just together.

Today.

And for the first time, Aarav didn't need anything more.

CHAPTER 23

After Today

Some stories ended with a goodbye.

Some ended with a wedding.

Some ended with two people walking into the sunset, believing that was enough to prove they would stay together forever.

Aarav never believed in endings like that anymore.

He had learned that life didn't stop just because a chapter did.

There were still ordinary mornings.

Long workdays.

Random arguments.

Unread messages.

Missed calls.

Coffee that got cold.

Plans that changed at the last minute.

And somehow, those ordinary things became the most beautiful part of life.

Because now, Aarav wasn't waiting for something to happen.

He was living.

A few months after that evening at the beach, Aarav and Meera had settled into a rhythm of their own.

Not a perfect one.

A real one.

Meera still complained when Aarav took too long to reply.

Aarav still made fun of her for ordering food and then stealing half of his.

She still sent him random pictures during the day.

He still saved the ones she didn't think were worth keeping.

And every once in a while, one of them would say something completely meaningless just to hear the other laugh.

One Sunday morning, Meera walked into Aarav's room carrying two cups of coffee.

She placed one beside him.

“Wake up.”

Aarav opened one eye.

“I'm awake.”

“You're literally sleeping.”

“I was thinking with my eyes closed.”

Meera stared at him.

“For five minutes?”

“Deep thinking.”

She picked up his pillow.

“Aarav.”

“Okay, okay.”

He finally sat up.

She smiled.

“Good morning.”

“Good morning.”

She handed him the coffee.

He took one sip.

Then looked at her.

“You made this?”

“Yes.”

“You're improving.”

Meera narrowed her eyes.

“Was that supposed to be a compliment?”

“Yes.”

“It sounded dangerous.”

Aarav laughed.

“I'm just saying the first time you made coffee, I thought you were trying to punish me.”

She hit him lightly with the pillow.

“Drink your coffee and shut up.”

He smiled.

There it was.

That same smile she had spent years trying to bring back.

Only now, she didn't have to try.

Later that afternoon, they went out.

No special restaurant.

No expensive plan.

Just a walk through the city, stopping wherever they felt like stopping.

At one point, they passed a college student couple sitting outside a café.

The girl was talking excitedly.

The boy was listening.

Meera looked at them and smiled.

“What?”

Aarav asked.

“Nothing.”

“You're smiling.”

“So?”

“You only smile like that when you're thinking something.”

Meera looked at him.

“I was just remembering college.”

Aarav nodded.

“Me too.”

“Do you miss it?”

He thought for a moment.

“Some parts.”

“Which parts?”

He smiled.

“The canteen.”

“Obviously.”

“The trips.”

“Obviously.”

“The library.”

“You never studied there.”

“I did.”

“You slept there.”

“That was also a form of studying.”

Meera laughed.

“And?”

Aarav looked at her.

“You.”

She stopped walking.

“What?”

“You asked which parts I miss.”

She smiled.

“You're getting better at this.”

“At what?”

“Being romantic without sounding like you're trying.”

Aarav laughed.

“I've had practice.”

“With me?”

“With life.”

She looked at him for a second.

Then quietly said,

“I'm glad you stayed.”

Aarav's smile softened.

“I'm glad you did too.”

That evening, they returned to the beach.

Not because something was wrong.

Not because they needed closure.

Not because they were trying to recreate the past.

They simply liked being there.

The waves were calm.

The sky was turning orange.

People walked along the shore.

Children ran around.

Someone was flying a kite in the distance.

Meera sat beside Aarav.

For a while, neither of them spoke.

Then she asked,

“Do you ever think about how different everything could've been?”

Aarav knew what she meant.

He looked toward the sea.

“Sometimes.”

“And?”

“I don't try to change it anymore.”

Meera nodded.

“Why?”

“Because if I changed the past…”

He turned toward her.

“…I might change the way I found you.”

Meera smiled.

“You really have become romantic.”

“Don't get used to it.”

“Too late.”

They laughed.

Then Aarav looked at the horizon.

There had been a time when the past felt like a room he couldn't leave.

Kiara.

The silence.

The misunderstanding.

The accident.

The guilt.

The loneliness.

Everything had once felt unfinished.

But now, it wasn't something he carried like a wound.

It was simply part of his story.

A chapter that had changed him.

A chapter he would never erase.

But also one he didn't need to reread every day.

Because life had continued.

And so had he.

Meera leaned her head against his shoulder.

“What's going on in your mind?”

Aarav smiled.

“Nothing.”

“Liar.”

He looked at her.

“I'm just thinking…”

“What?”

“That maybe happiness isn't one big moment.”

Meera waited.

“Maybe it's all these small things.”

He looked around.

“This.”

She looked at him.

“Us.”

He nodded.

“The coffee in the morning. Your stupid messages. Fighting over food. Random walks. Coming back to the same beach.”

Meera smiled.

“And stealing your fries.”

“Especially that.”

She laughed.

Aarav looked at her and realized something.

For years, he had thought love was supposed to feel like something dramatic.

Something impossible to lose.

Something that made the world stop.

But now he understood.

Maybe real love wasn't about the world stopping.

Maybe it was about finding someone who made you want to keep moving through it.

Together.

The sun disappeared completely.

The lights along the beach began to glow.

Meera stood up.

“Come on.”

“Where?”

“Home.”

Aarav stood beside her.

They started walking.

After a few steps, Meera reached for his hand.

He held it.

Neither of them said anything.

They didn't need to.

Because some moments didn't need a speech.

Some feelings didn't need a name.

And some people didn't need to promise forever.

They simply stayed.

Step by step.

Day by day.

After everything.

After yesterday.

After all the things they couldn't change.

There was still tomorrow.

And for Aarav, that was enough.

He looked at Meera.

She smiled.

He smiled back.

And together, they walked home.

Not toward the past.

Not toward some perfect future.

Just forward.

Together.

CHAPTER 24

The Life We Built

Three years later.

Mumbai had changed.

Or maybe Aarav had.

The roads were still crowded.

The local trains were still packed.

The rain still arrived without warning.

And the city still somehow made everyone feel like they were always running late.

But Aarav no longer felt like he was running away from anything.

He had a job he liked.

A small apartment that still had boxes in places they probably shouldn't have been.

A coffee machine that Meera insisted was necessary.

And a person who had somehow become part of every ordinary moment of his life.

Meera.

“Where are my keys?”

Aarav stood in the middle of the living room.

Meera looked up from the sofa.

“Which keys?”

“My house keys.”

“You had them five minutes ago.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you asking me?”

“Because you usually know where everything is.”

Meera smiled.

“That sounds like a compliment.”

“It is.”

She pointed toward the kitchen.

“Check there.”

Aarav walked into the kitchen.

Nothing.

He came back.

“Not there.”

Meera sighed.

“Check your pocket.”

Aarav put his hand into his pocket.

The keys were there.

He stared at them.

Meera started laughing.

“Don't say anything.”

“I wasn't going to.”

“You're laughing.”

“I can laugh silently.”

“You're terrible.”

She smiled.

“You're welcome.”

Aarav shook his head.

He had once believed that the happiest moments of his life would be the extraordinary ones.

Trips.

Proposals.

Graduation.

Big celebrations.

But somehow, years later, he realized his favorite moments were things like this.

Looking for keys.

Arguing about coffee.

Choosing what to eat.

Sending each other stupid memes.

Falling asleep during movies.

Waiting for the other person to come home.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing perfect.

Just life.

Their life.

That evening, Meera came home earlier than usual.

Aarav noticed immediately.

“You're early.”

“I have something for you.”

He looked suspicious.

“What did you buy?”

“Why do you assume I bought something?”

“Because you said you have something for me.”

She handed him a small envelope.

Aarav looked at it.

“What is this?”

“Open it.”

He opened the envelope.

Inside was a photograph.

He stared at it.

It was old.

Very old.

A college photograph.

The three of them.

Aarav.

Kiara.

Meera.

It was from one of those random college days when everyone had taken pictures without thinking they would matter years later.

Aarav smiled.

“You kept this?”

“I found it while cleaning.”

He looked at the photograph again.

For a moment, memories came rushing back.

The first day.

The canteen.

The jokes.

The fights.

The silence.

The beach.

Matheran.

The lights.

The ride back.

The apology.

The graduation.

Everything.

Meera watched him quietly.

“You okay?”

Aarav nodded.

“Yeah.”

He smiled.

“I actually like this.”

“Why?”

“Because it's proof that all three of us were part of the same story.”

Meera sat beside him.

“You don't feel sad?”

Aarav thought about it.

“A little.”

She waited.

“But not in a bad way.”

He looked at the photograph.

“Some people are important because they stay.”

He paused.

“Some are important because they changed you.”

Meera nodded.

“And some?”

Aarav smiled.

“They're important because they taught you what you really wanted.”

Meera looked at him.

“And what did you want?”

Aarav looked at her.

“A life where I didn't have to keep looking backward.”

She smiled.

“You got that.”

“I did.”

Later that night, Aarav placed the photograph inside a small drawer.

Not hidden.

Not displayed.

Just kept safely.

Meera watched him.

“Why don't you put it somewhere?”

“Where?”

“On the shelf.”

Aarav smiled.

“Maybe someday.”

She nodded.

They turned off the lights.

The apartment became quiet.

A few minutes later, Meera spoke.

“Aarav?”

“Hmm?”

“Are you happy?”

He opened his eyes.

There was a time when that question would have frightened him.

He would have searched for the perfect answer.

Tonight, he didn't need one.

“Yes.”

Meera smiled in the darkness.

“Good.”

“Why did you ask?”

“Nothing.”

“You're hiding something.”

“No.”

“Meera.”

She laughed softly.

“Fine.”

She turned toward him.

“I just wanted to know.”

Aarav looked at her.

“You don't have to keep checking.”

“Why?”

“Because if something ever changes…”

He paused.

“I'll tell you.”

She smiled.

“Promise?”

“Promise.”

She moved closer.

“Good.”

The room became quiet again.

And Aarav smiled.

Because that was the difference between then and now.

Back then, silence meant something was wrong.

Now, silence simply meant they were comfortable.

The next morning, Aarav woke before Meera.

Sunlight came through the curtains.

He got up quietly and went into the kitchen.

He made two cups of coffee.

One for himself.

One for her.

When he returned, Meera was awake.

She looked at the coffee.

Then at him.

“You made it?”

“Yes.”

She took the cup.

“Wow.”

“What?”

“You're finally useful.”

Aarav laughed.

“Good morning to you too.”

She smiled.

“Good morning.”

He sat beside her.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Meera looked at him.

“You know what I realized?”

“What?”

“We've known each other for years.”

Aarav nodded.

“And somehow…”

She smiled.

“I still like waking up next to you.”

Aarav looked at her.

“Some things don't need to change.”

She rested her head against his shoulder.

Outside, Mumbai had already begun another busy day.

Cars moved.

People hurried.

Phones rang.

Life continued.

And inside that little apartment, two people sat quietly with their morning coffee.

No promises about forever.

No fear of yesterday.

No need to know exactly what tomorrow would bring.

Just two people who had chosen each other again and again.

Not once.

Not dramatically.

But in hundreds of ordinary moments.

And perhaps that was what love really was.

Not finding someone who made your life perfect.

But finding someone with whom you wanted to build an imperfect life.

A real one.

A quiet one.

A life that belonged to both of you.

A life they had not planned.

A life they had not expected.

A life they had built—

one ordinary day at a time.

CHAPTER 25

Forever, Somehow

Five years after college, Aarav still remembered the first day.

Not every detail.

Not every conversation.

But the feeling.

The nervousness.

The unfamiliar faces.

The noise of St. Aurelia College.

Kiara walking toward him.

Meera standing somewhere in the crowd, watching from a distance.

He had no idea then that those ordinary college days would become the memories he would carry for the rest of his life.

He had no idea that he would lose someone he thought would always be there.

He had no idea that someone else would quietly stay.

And he certainly had no idea that the girl he once barely noticed would eventually become home.

Life was strange like that.

Sometimes the people who changed your life weren't the ones you expected.

Sometimes they were simply the ones who stayed long enough for you to notice them.

It was a Sunday evening.

Aarav and Meera were sitting on their balcony.

Two cups of coffee sat on the table.

The city stretched endlessly in front of them.

Meera was scrolling through her phone.

Aarav was looking at the sky.

“You're quiet,” Meera said.

“So are you.”

“I was reading.”

“You've been staring at the same message for five minutes.”

She looked at him.

“How do you notice everything?”

“I've always noticed everything.”

Meera smiled.

“I know.”

Aarav looked at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

She put her phone down.

“Do you remember the first time we talked?”

Aarav laughed.

“At college?”

“Yes.”

“You barely talked to me.”

“I was shy.”

“You?”

“Yes, me.”

“I don't believe that.”

She smiled.

“I was.”

Aarav thought for a moment.

“I remember.”

“You were sitting alone.”

“Yeah.”

“And I asked if I could sit there.”

“You asked because you felt bad for me.”

“I did not.”

“You did.”

“I thought you looked lonely.”

“I was.”

Meera became quiet.

Aarav looked at her.

“But you sat down.”

She smiled.

“And I never really left.”

Aarav smiled back.

“I'm glad.”

A few weeks later, they returned to their college.

St. Aurelia looked smaller than Aarav remembered.

The corridors seemed narrower.

The classrooms seemed less intimidating.

The canteen seemed much more crowded.

They walked slowly through the campus.

Students passed them without knowing who they were.

To those students, Aarav and Meera were just another couple walking through college.

But to Aarav, every corner held a memory.

The staircase where he and Kiara used to sit.

The canteen table where their group spent hours.

The corridor where Meera once walked away without him noticing.

The classroom where friendships became complicated.

The place where everything had once felt like it was falling apart.

And the same college where, somehow, everything eventually came together.

Meera noticed him looking around.

“Thinking about the past?”

“A little.”

“Want to talk about it?”

Aarav smiled.

“Not really.”

“Why?”

“Because I don't miss it.”

She looked surprised.

“You don't?”

“I miss the memories.”

He looked around.

“But I don't want to go back.”

Meera smiled.

“That's different.”

“Very.”

They continued walking.

Before leaving, Aarav stopped near the old college notice board.

There was a faded photograph pinned there from years ago.

A group photograph.

He looked closer.

There he was.

Kiara was standing beside him.

Meera was somewhere behind them.

Aarav smiled.

Meera stood beside him.

“Funny,” she said.

“What?”

“We were all in the same picture.”

“And none of us knew what was coming.”

She was right.

None of them had.

Aarav took one last look.

Then he stepped away.

No sadness.

No regret.

Just gratitude.

That night, Aarav and Meera returned to the beach.

The same beach.

The same place where their story had truly begun.

They sat beside each other.

The waves moved gently toward the shore.

Meera looked at him.

“Do you ever think about the title?”

Aarav smiled.

“Of what?”

“Your story.”

He looked at her.

“The Person I Couldn't Forget.”

Meera nodded.

“You know, for a long time I thought that title was about someone you couldn't let go of.”

Aarav stayed quiet.

“But now?”

He looked toward the sea.

“Now I think it's about everyone who leaves something behind.”

Meera listened.

“Kiara will always be part of my story.”

He paused.

“So will college.”

Another pause.

“So will the version of me who was lost.”

Meera smiled.

“And me?”

Aarav looked at her.

“You're not someone I couldn't forget.”

She raised an eyebrow.

“No?”

He smiled.

“You're someone I don't want to forget.”

Her expression softened.

“That's better.”

“Much better.”

She rested her head against his shoulder.

The evening slowly became darker.

Aarav looked at the horizon.

He thought about everything that had happened.

The friendship that had broken.

The misunderstanding that had lasted too long.

The person who had returned.

The person who had stayed.

The boy he had been.

The man he had become.

For years, he had believed that moving on meant forgetting.

Now he understood.

Moving on didn't mean erasing the past.

It meant remembering it without being trapped inside it.

It meant being grateful for what happened without wishing to relive it.

It meant choosing the present.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Aarav reached for Meera's hand.

She held it.

“Ready to go?”

She asked.

Aarav smiled.

“In a minute.”

They stayed there a little longer.

Neither of them wanted to rush the moment.

Because some places weren't special because of what happened there.

They were special because of what they meant afterward.

Years ago, Aarav had sat on that same beach believing he had lost everything.

He had thought the person he couldn't forget was the person he needed to find again.

He was wrong.

He didn't need to go backward.

He needed to notice who was standing beside him.

And when he finally did, his life changed.

Not suddenly.

Not perfectly.

But slowly.

Beautifully.

One conversation.

One friendship.

One laugh.

One difficult day.

One second chance.

One ordinary moment at a time.

He looked at Meera.

She smiled.

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

Aarav shook his head.

“Just thinking.”

“About?”

He smiled.

“Nothing important.”

“Liar.”

He laughed.

Then he stood and offered her his hand.

“Come on.”

She took it.

They began walking.

The waves continued behind them.

The city lights appeared ahead.

And for the first time, Aarav didn't feel the need to look back.

Because he had finally understood something simple.

Some people become memories.

Some become lessons.

Some become chapters.

And once in a while—

someone becomes the person you choose to keep writing the story with.

Meera squeezed his hand.

Aarav looked at her.

She smiled.

And they kept walking.

Not toward forever.

Not away from yesterday.

Just toward another ordinary day together.

And somehow,

that was enough.

The End.

THE END

Thank you for reading.

The Ink House